“Introduction to Music History”

A short Cantata for Soprano and two Tenors (with piano accompaniment)

Composed by Kevin Tran

(2026)

Synopsis

Introduction to Music History is a three-part cantata for Soprano and two Tenors with piano accompaniment.

Loosely based off the first-year class by the same name, it follows **Katie**, a student in the Music History class of the eccentric **Prof. Geiger**, on her quest to discover the final term paper rubric. Along the way, she asks her TA, **Peter,** who is of little help at first but agrees to go along with her to confront the professor about the marking scheme for the final term paper anyway.

Program notes

In the first part, **Prof. Geiger** speaks to a lecture hall in Music history class, announcing the final term paper. This is followed by a da capo Aria sung by the professor.

The following are remarkable programmatic features:

- The wandering impetus and undulating melodic phrases are representative of the ramblings of an eccentric professor.
- The accompaniment reflects for the audience the internal thoughts of **Prof. Geiger**. For example, when Geiger references Mozart, the audience will hear Mozart, or when Geiger mentions Haydn, the audience will hear Haydn, etc.
- In the B section, the accompaniment figuration programmatically represents the “horns of cuckoldry”.
- There are specific references to listenings and course material from the class which this cantata is based off.

In the second part, after gaining confusion regarding the marking scheme for the final term paper, **Katie** goes to her TA, seeking guidance:

Thus begins the duet (written in sonata allegro form), where the following are a few notable features to listen for:

- In the A section, jaunty rhythms and unpredictable harmonies underscore **Katie**'s unease.
- In the first iteration of the subordinate theme, elements in **Peter**'s solo (graceful tempo, triple meter, diatonic harmony) reflect how **Peter** is blissful and dismissive of **Katie**'s situation.
- At the culmination of **Katie**'s agitation in the exposition, the accompaniment foreshadows the motif used in the core of the development section.
- In the C section the accompaniment figuration refers to the "horns of cuckoldry" once again, only this time in triple meter.

Finally, in the third part, **Peter** agrees to go with **Katie** to confront **Prof. Geiger** on the marking scheme for the final assignment. Here are some things to listen for:

- The piano introduction references the rhythmic motif from the main theme of the previous movement, establishing how **Katie** still feels agitated.
- The movement is written in a five-part rondo form where every episode references material from a previous movement in some way (for example, **Prof. Geiger** sings his aria, and **Peter** sings material from his solo in the second movement).
- The "horns of cuckoldry" motif appears several times in the accompaniment, used transitionally to **Prof. Geiger**'s theme, and in **Peter**'s episode (section D).

—RECITS—

These recitatives proceed each respective score

KevinTran

PART ONE—IN THE LECTURE HALL

(RECITATIVE)

PROF. GEIGER:

Welcome, welcome.

Ah—yes, yes, we're midway through the term, aren't we?
It is time—at last—for your final essay!

Now, before you panic, let me assure you:
there is no rubric.
Rubrics are for bureaucrats and cowards.
You will know what I want when you have already written it.

PETER:

Peter stands beside the student and whispers:

I have no idea what he's talking about.

PROF. GEIGER:

The topic, my dear scholars,
is the beating heart beneath all great art—
that restless pulse that moves from Machaut to Mahler!

Prof. Geiger closes his eyes contemplatively

There's a word I'm thinking of...
It's on the tip of my tongue—
Can any of you guess the word I'm thinking of?

Student stares blankly at prof. Geiger

...Erotic!

PART TWO—IN A TUTORIAL CLASSROOM

(RECITATIVE)

KATIE:
Peter, excuse me… we need to know how this essay is being marked!

There's no rubric!

PETER (still addressing the class, unbothered):
Yes, yes… grading. Important.
Honestly, just go ask the Professor.
He's the one with the official answer.
I'm mostly here to… facilitate discussion…

KATIE:
But Peter, we can't just guess!
We need to know what counts, how it's weighted…

PETER (to class, waving a hand):
See, this is where the fun begins!
Ask questions. Explore. Compare Renaissance cadences to… anything you want.
Hyperpop, jazz, bird calls… whatever inspires you.

KATIE:
Unbelievable…

PART THREE—IN THE PROFESSOR'S OFFICE

(RECITATIVE)

KATIE and PETER stand in the Hallway outside DR. GEIGER's office.

PETER
He's usually here now.

KATIE
Okay.

A beat.

KATIE
You really don't know how it's marked?

PETER
I've graded for him before.
I know what he likes when I see it.
I don't know how to explain it before.

KATIE
So you just... feel it?

PETER
Yeah.
Which is not helpful.
I'm aware.

A chair scrapes inside the office.

PETER
(quickly)
He's actually really nice.

KATIE
I'm not worried about him being mean.

PETER
Good.
Because he won't be.

They step closer. PETER knocks lightly.

DR. GEIGER (inside)
Yes?

They enter. DR. GEIGER looks up, already smiling, as if he's been expecting this.

DR. GEIGER
Peter.
And—Katie, right?

KATIE
Yes.

DR. GEIGER
Come in.
You're not interrupting.

They sit. Silence settles — not awkward, but dense.

DR. GEIGER
So.
What's on your mind?

KATIE glances at PETER. He nods: go ahead.

KATIE
I just wanted to ask about the paper.

DR. GEIGER
Of course.

A slight pause. DR. GEIGER folds his hands.

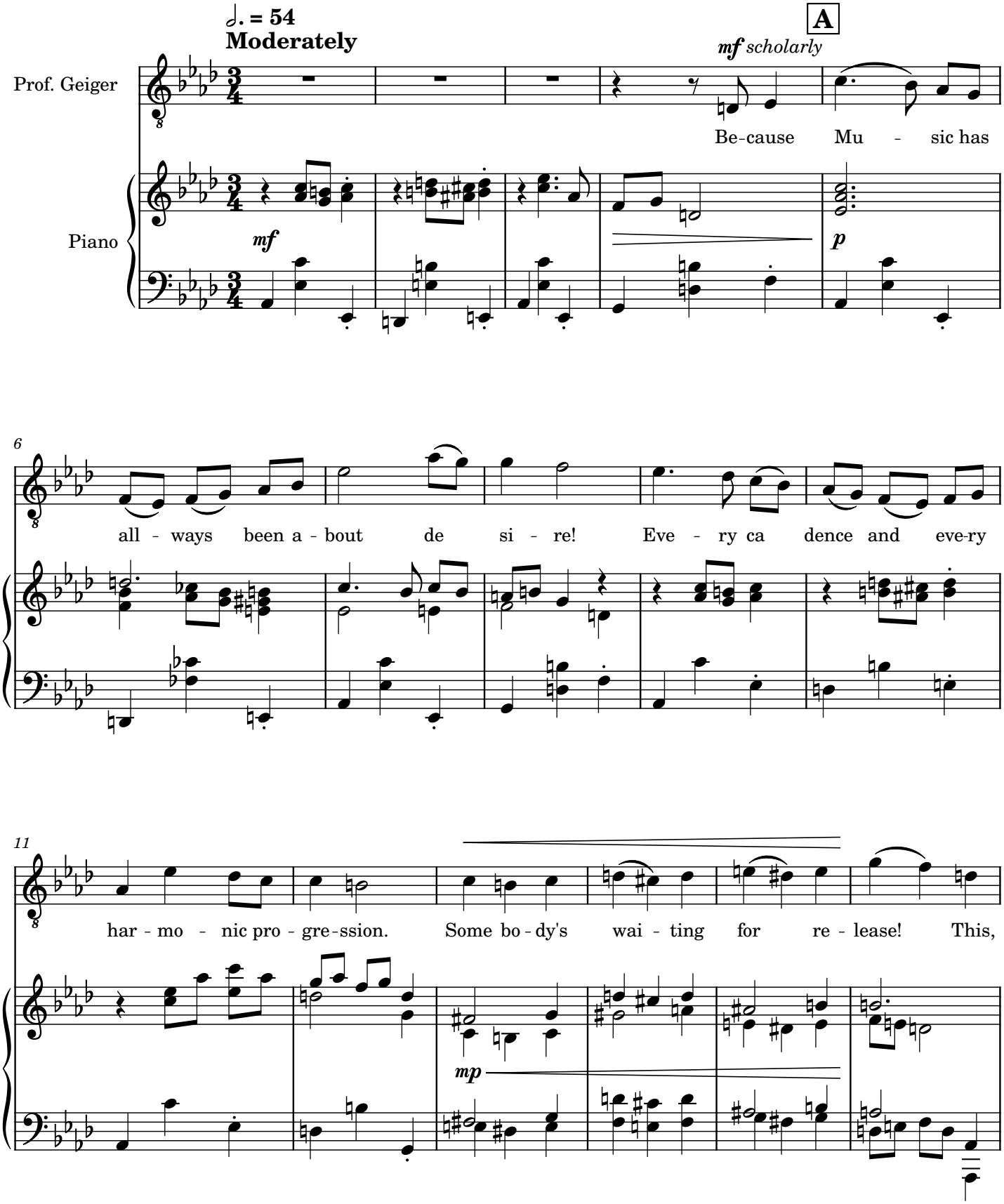
—SCORES—

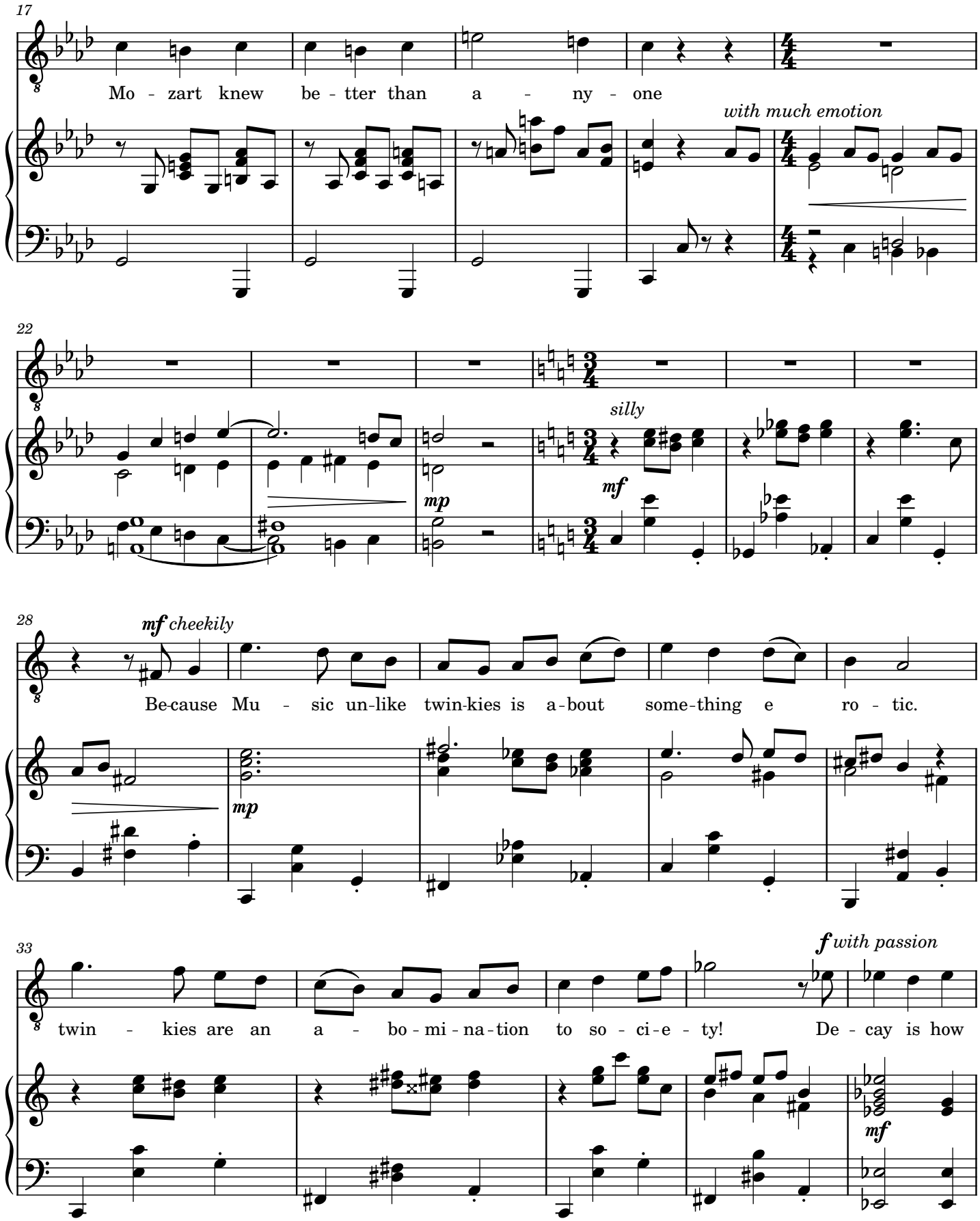
Kevin Tran

No.1. Aria.

"There's this word I'm thinking of..."

Kevin Tran (b. 2006)




17
Mo - zart knew be - tter than a - ny - one
with much emotion
22
silly
mf
mp
28
mf cheekily
Be-cause Mu - sic un-like twin-kies is a-bout some-thing e ro - tic.
mp
33
f with passion
twin - kies are an a - bo - mi - na - tion to so - ci - e - ty! De - cay is how
mf

38

nat - ure main - tains ba - lance, This, Mo - zart knew be - tter than a - ny -

44

-one

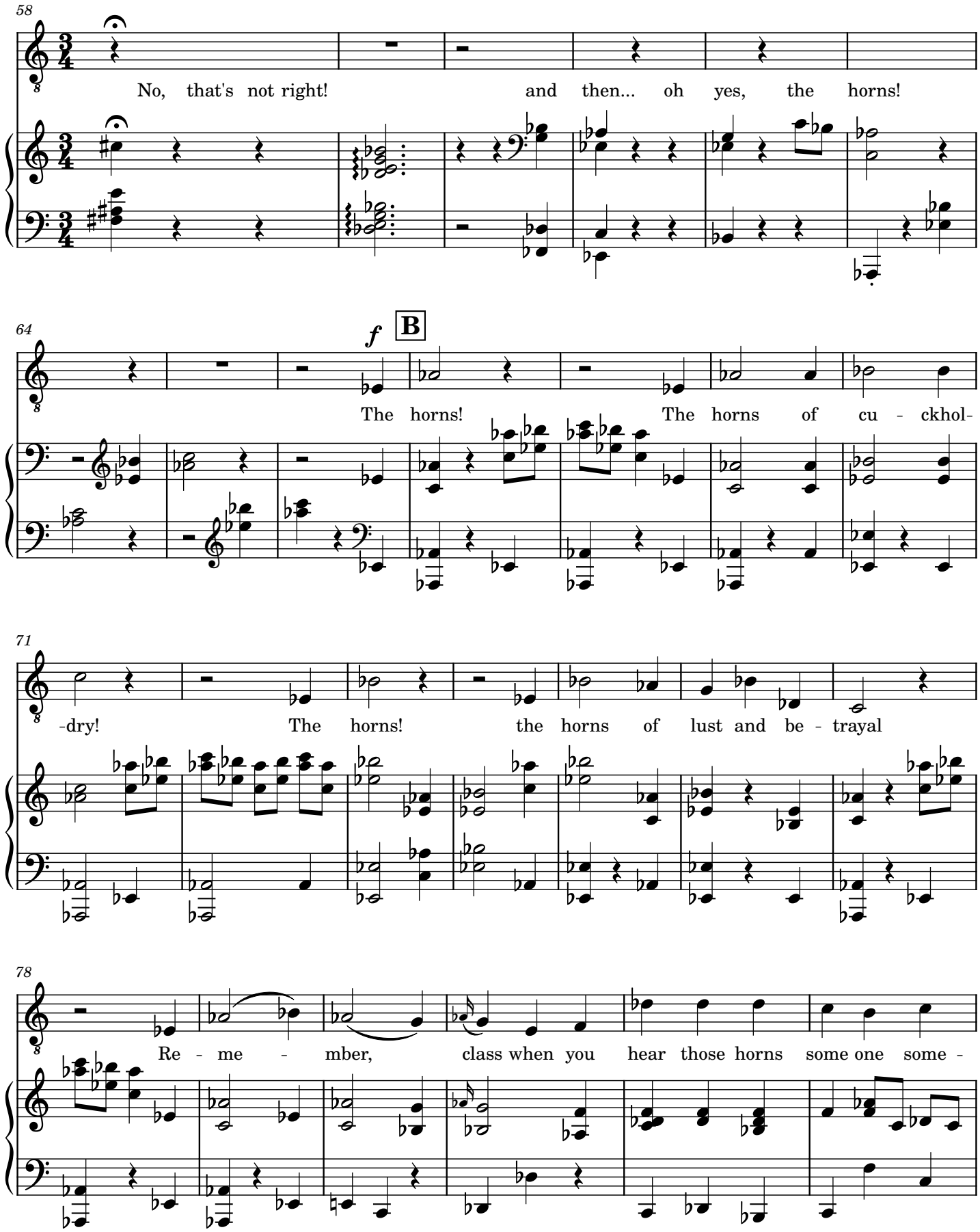
tentatively

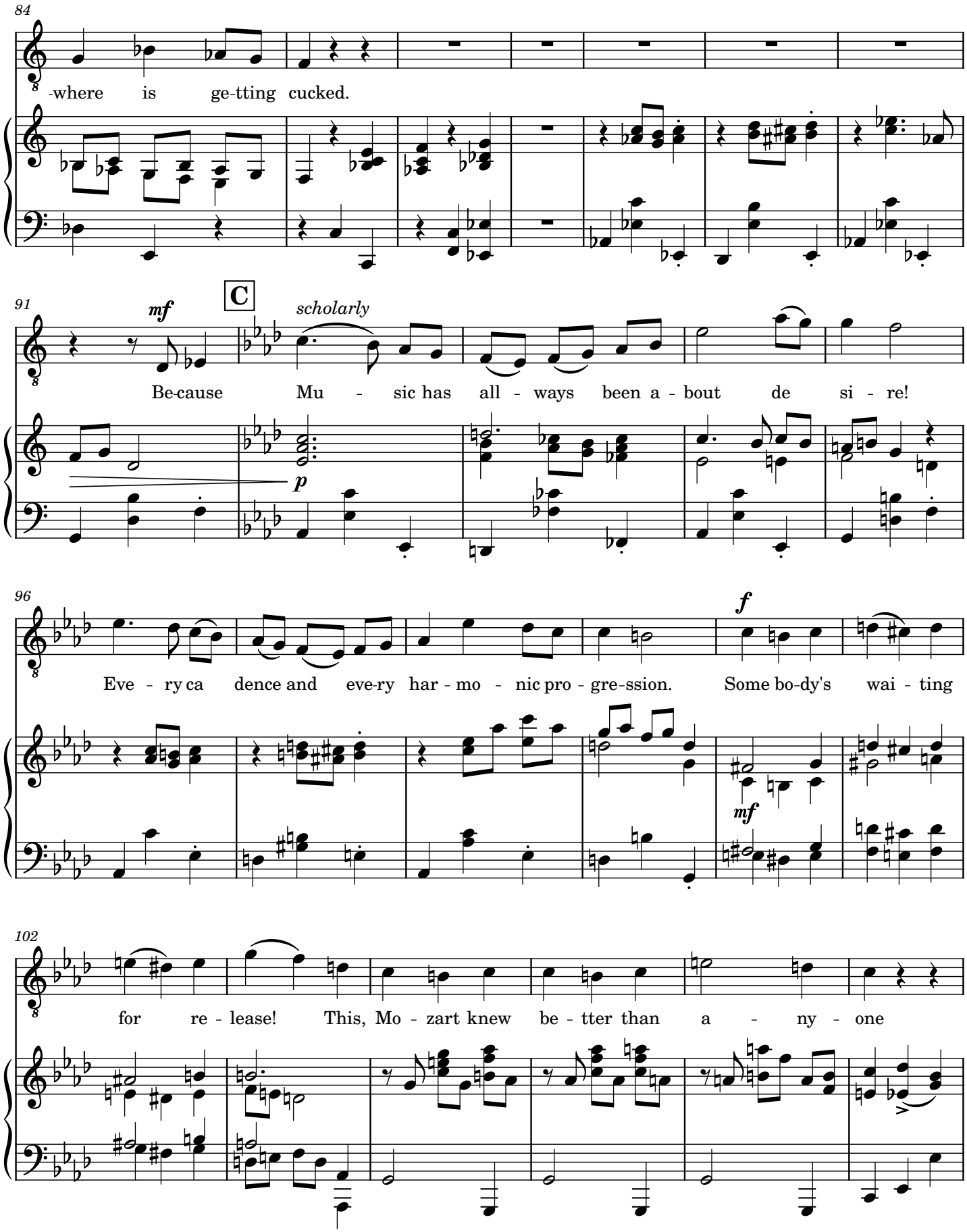
mf

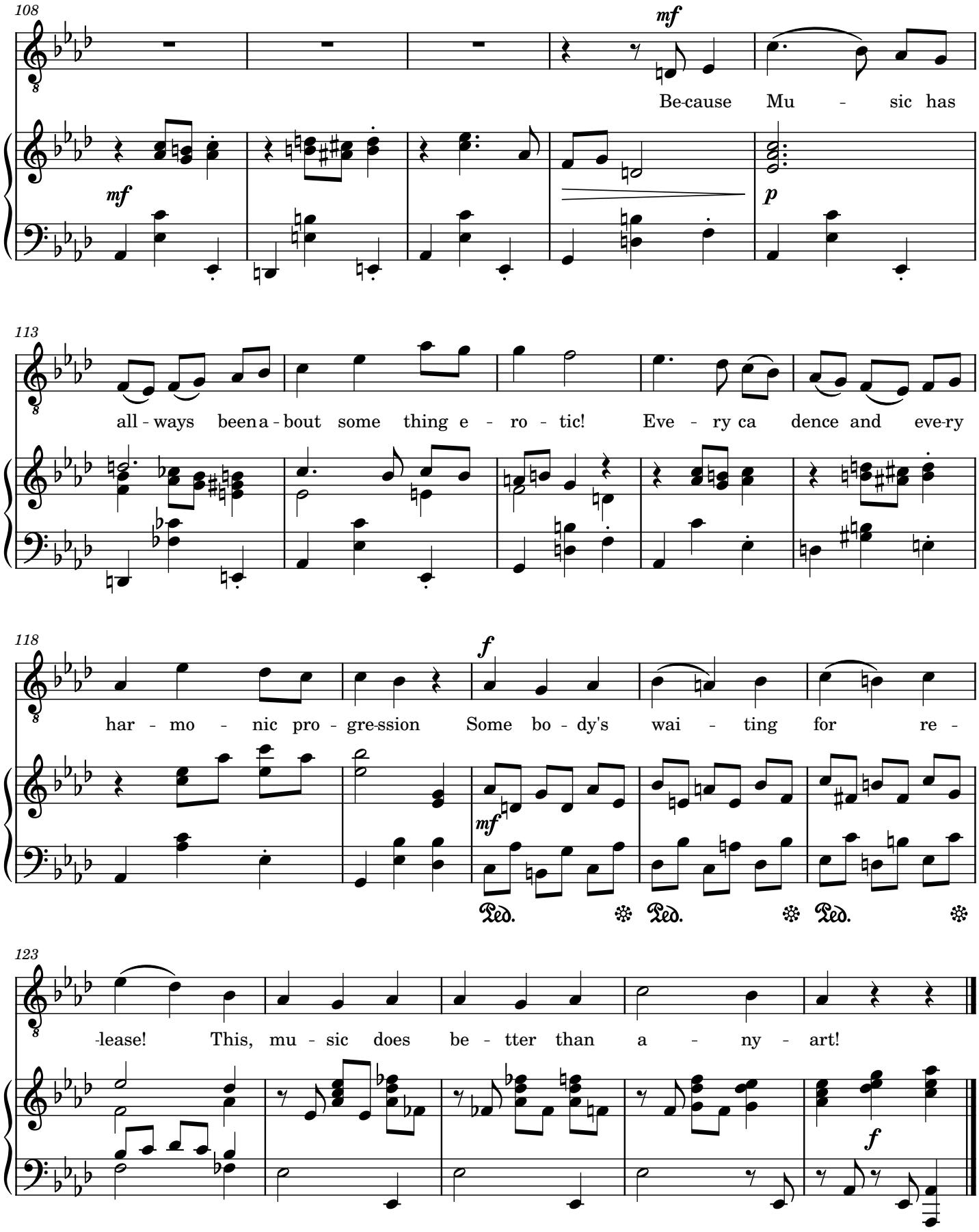
49

Hmm... what was I talking about again? *(rustles through papers) Haydn?

51


58
No, that's not right! and then... oh yes, the horns!
64
f
B
The horns! The horns of cu - ckhol-
71
-dry! The horns! the horns of lust and be - trayal
78
Re - me - mber, class when you hear those horns some one some -

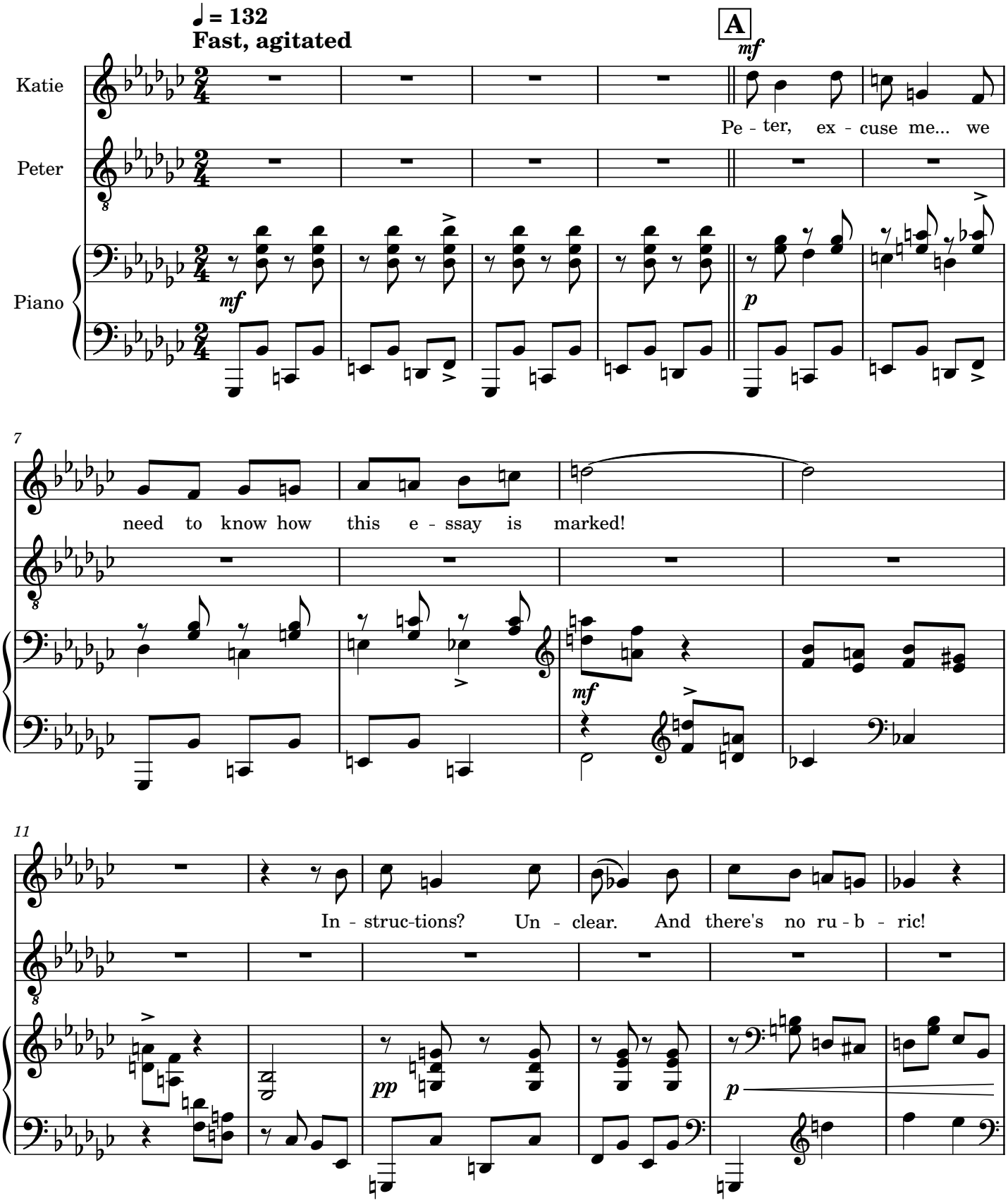

84
-where is ge-tting cucked.
91
mf
C
scholarly
Be-cause Mu - sic has all - ways been a - bout de si - re!
p
96
f
Eve - ry ca dence and eve-ry har - mo - nic pro - gre-ssion. Some bo-dy's wai - ting
mf
102
for re - lease! This, Mo - zart knew be - tter than a - ny - one


108
mf
Be-cause Mu - sic has
mf
p
113
all - ways been a - bout some thing e - ro - tic! Eve - ry ca dence and eve-ry
118
f
har - mo - nic pro - gre-ssion Some bo - dy's wai - ting for re -
mf
Ped. Ped. Ped.
123
-lease! This, mu - sic does be - tter than a - ny - art!
f

No. 2. Duet

"Peter e-excuse me?"

Kevin Tran (b.2006)



17

Pe - ter, e - cuse me... we need to know how this e-ssay is

mf

Yes, Yes ... Ka - tie what

f *p*

Ped.

23

marked!

f

Pe-ter, e - cuse me... we

mf

is it?

Yes, Yes ...

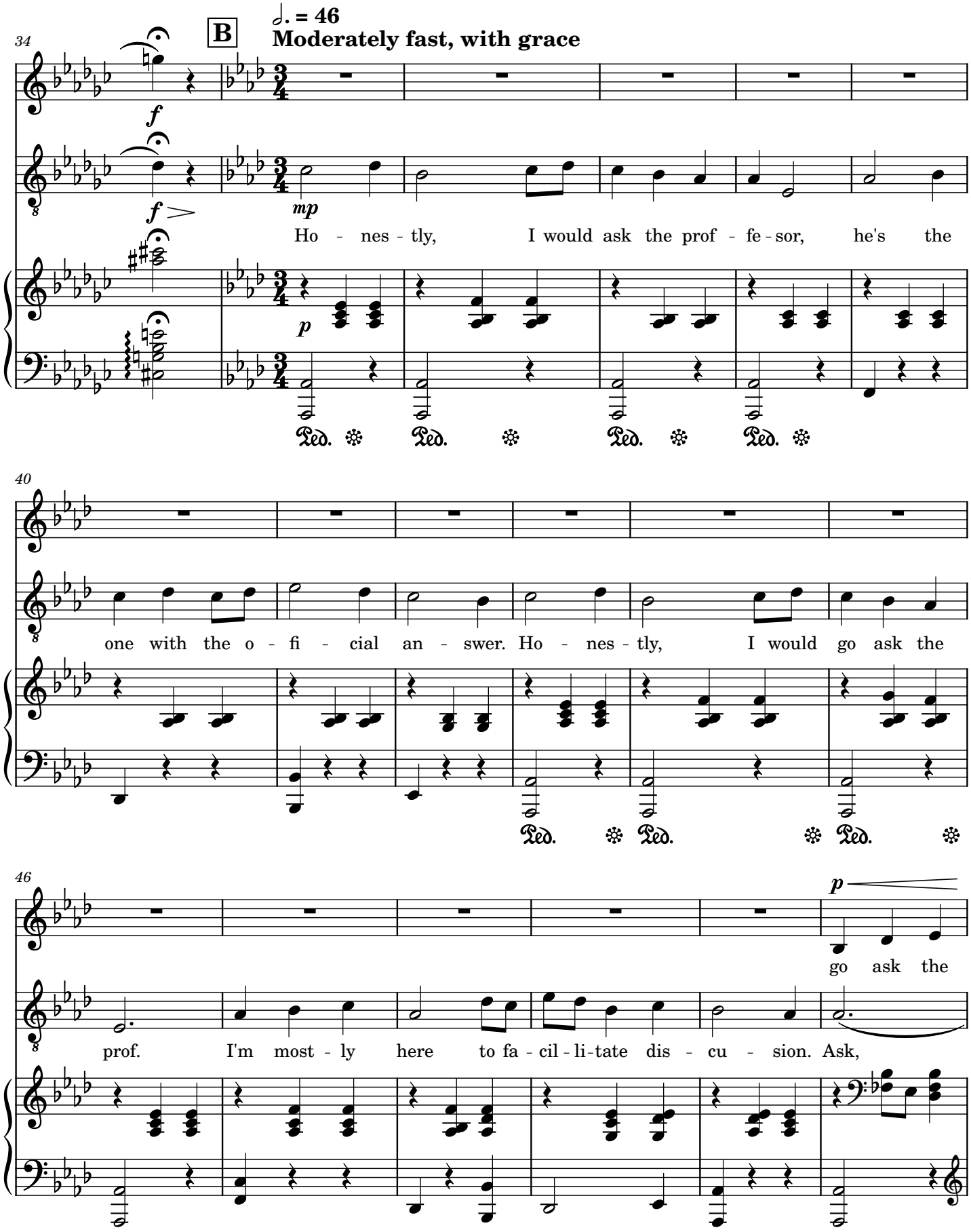
mf *f* *mp* *p*

29

need to know how this e-ssay is marked!

Ka - tie gra-ding is im - por - tant... I think?

mf


34
B
♩. = 46
Moderately fast, with grace
f
mp
Ho - nes - tly, I would ask the prof - fe - sor, he's the
p
Ped.
40
one with the o - fi - cial an - swer. Ho - nes - tly, I would go ask the
46
p
go ask the
prof. I'm most - ly here to fa - cil - li - tate dis - cu - sion. Ask,

52

mf *p* *p* *mf*

prof? go ask the prof?

yes, go ask the prof. Ask, yes, go ask the

58

mp **accel.** *cresc.*

Go ask the prof? are you se - ri - ous, what e - ven is your

prof!

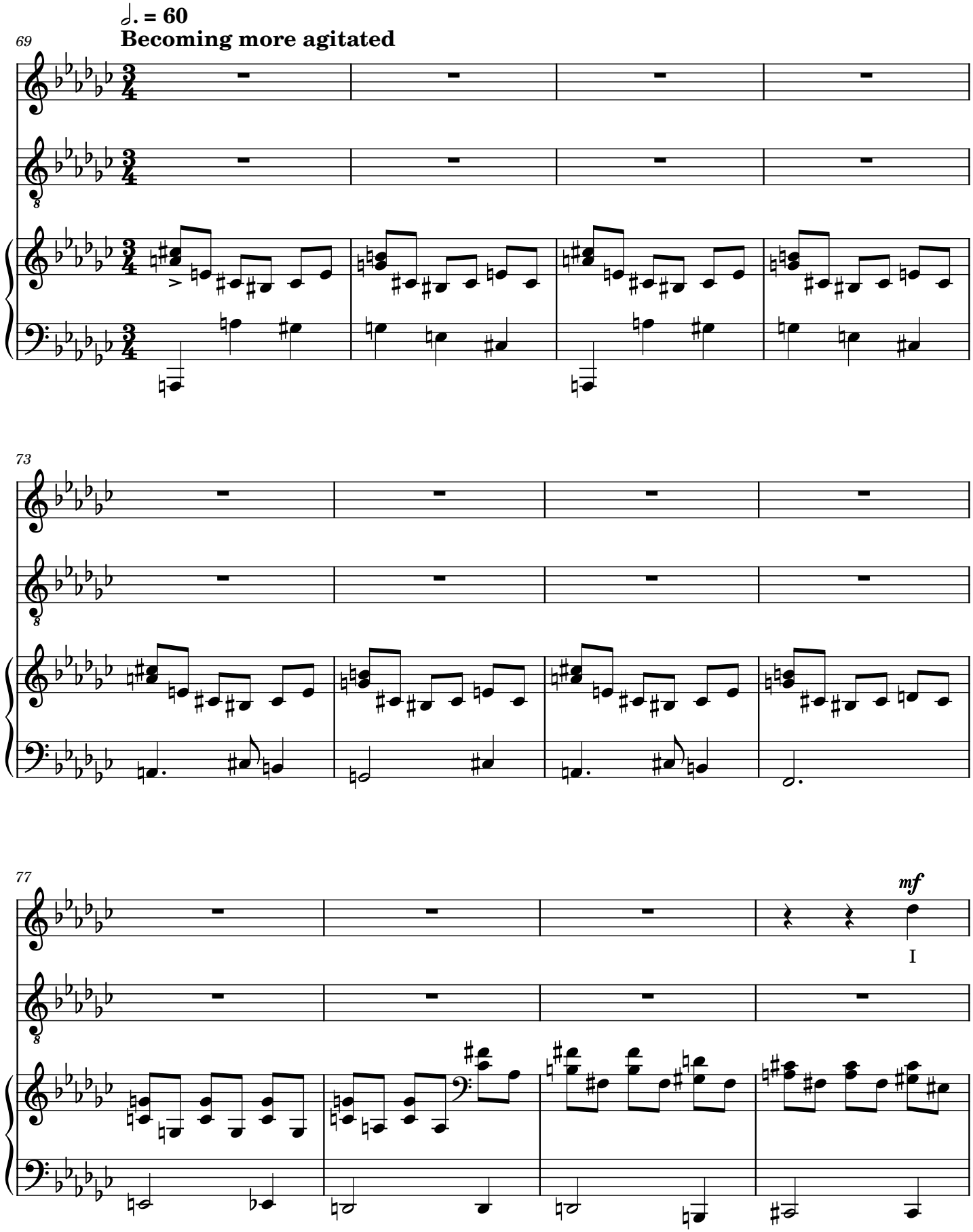
cresc.

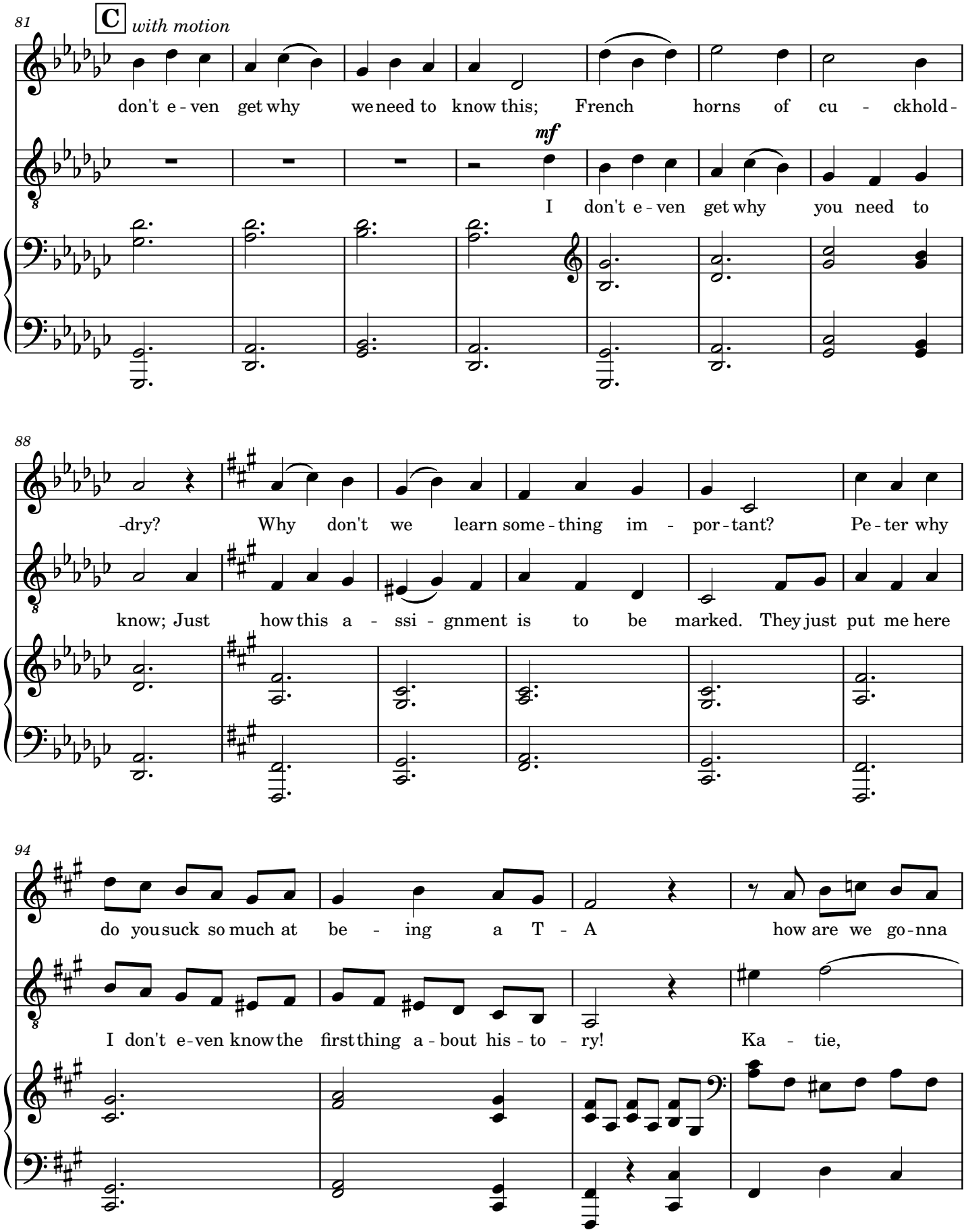
64

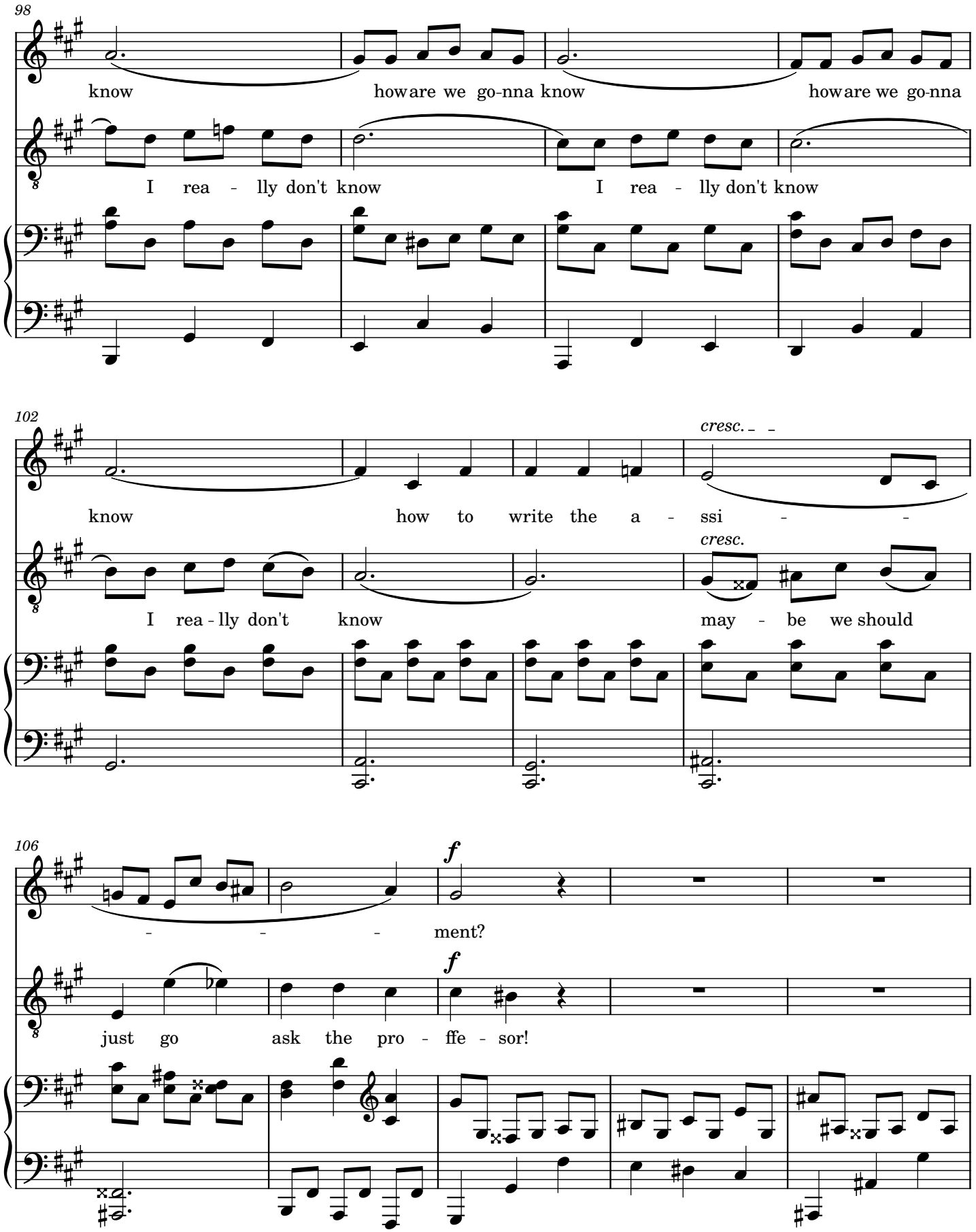
f

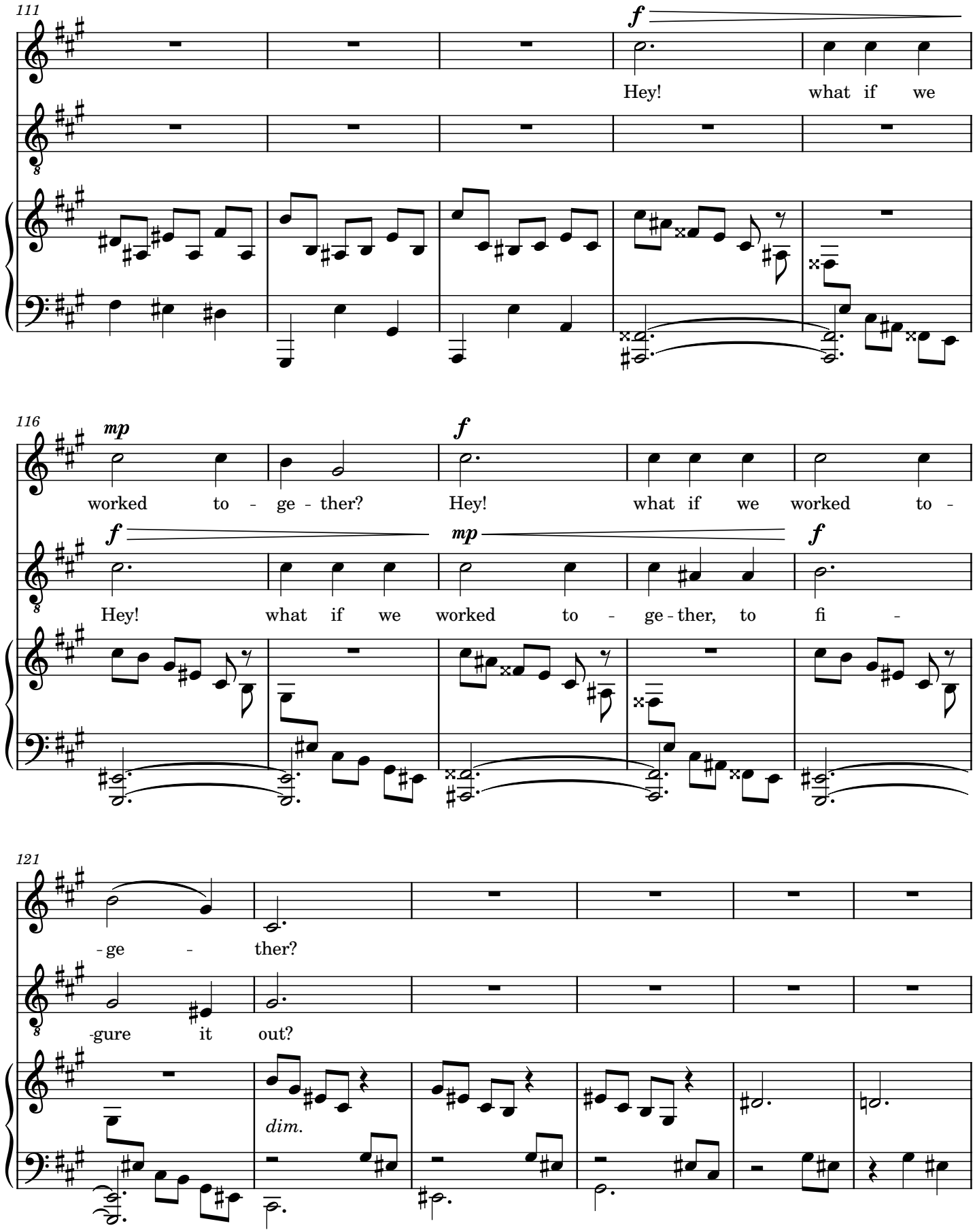
job!

mf


𝅗𝅥. = 60
Becoming more agitated
69
73
77
mf
I


81
C
with motion
don't e - ven get why we need to know this; French horns of cu - ckhold -
mf
I don't e - ven get why you need to
88
-dry? Why don't we learn some - thing im - por - tant? Pe - ter why
know; Just how this a - ssi - gnment is to be marked. They just put me here
94
do you suck so much at be - ing a T - A how are we go - nna
I don't e - ven know the first thing a - bout his - to - ry! Ka - tie,


98
know
howare we go-nna know
howare we go-nna
I rea - lly don't know
I rea - lly don't know
102
know
how to write the a - ssi - -
cresc.
I rea - lly don't know
may - be we should
cresc.
106
- - - ment?
f
just go ask the pro - ffe - sor!
f


111
f
Hey! what if we
116
mp
f
worked to - ge - ther? Hey! what if we worked to -
f
mp
f
Hey! what if we worked to - ge - ther, to fi -
121
- ge - ther?
-gure it out?
dim.

127

♩ = 132
First tempo

D

mf

Pe-ter, e-

p

mf

p

134

-cuse me... we need to know how this e-ssay is marked!

mf

140

In-struc-tions? Un-clear: and there's no ru-b-ric!

pp

p

f

146

Pe-ter, e - cuse me... we need to know how this e-ssay is marked!

mf *f*

Yes, Yes ... Ka - tie what is it?

p *mf*

Ped.

152

Pe-ter, e - cuse me... we need to know how

mf

Yes, Yes ... Ka - tie

f *mp* *p*

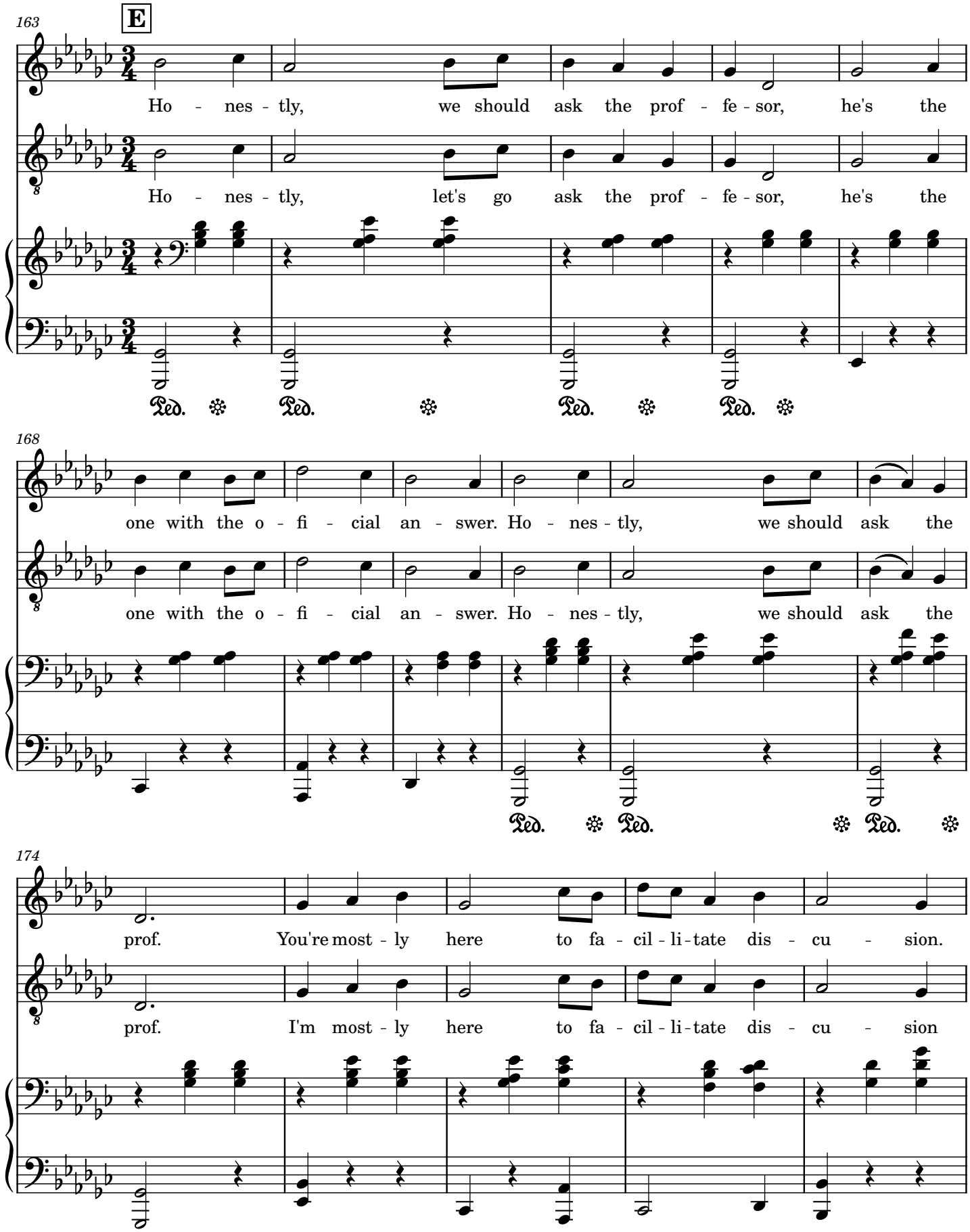
158

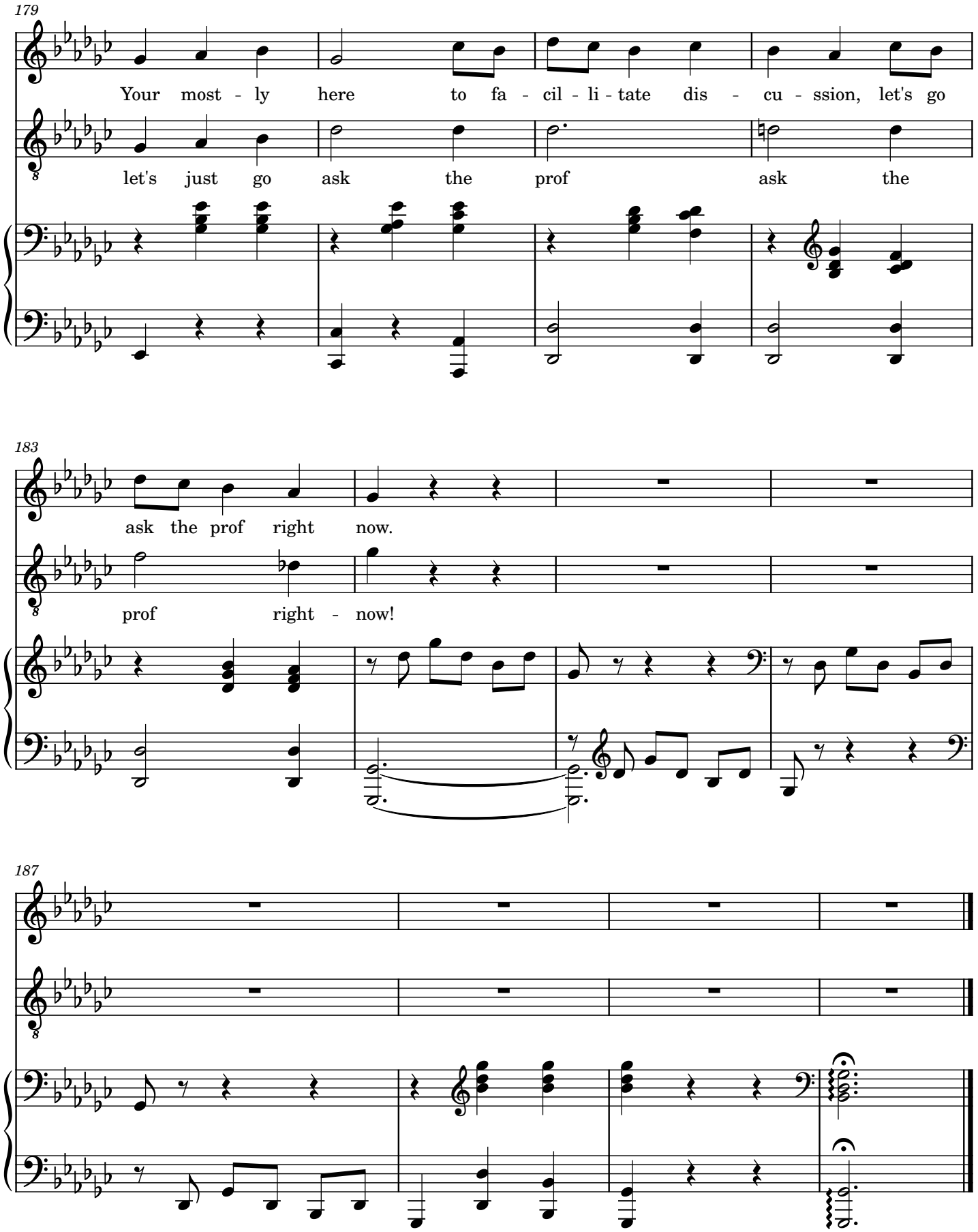
this e-ssay is marked!

f

gra-ding is im - por - tant... I think?

mf

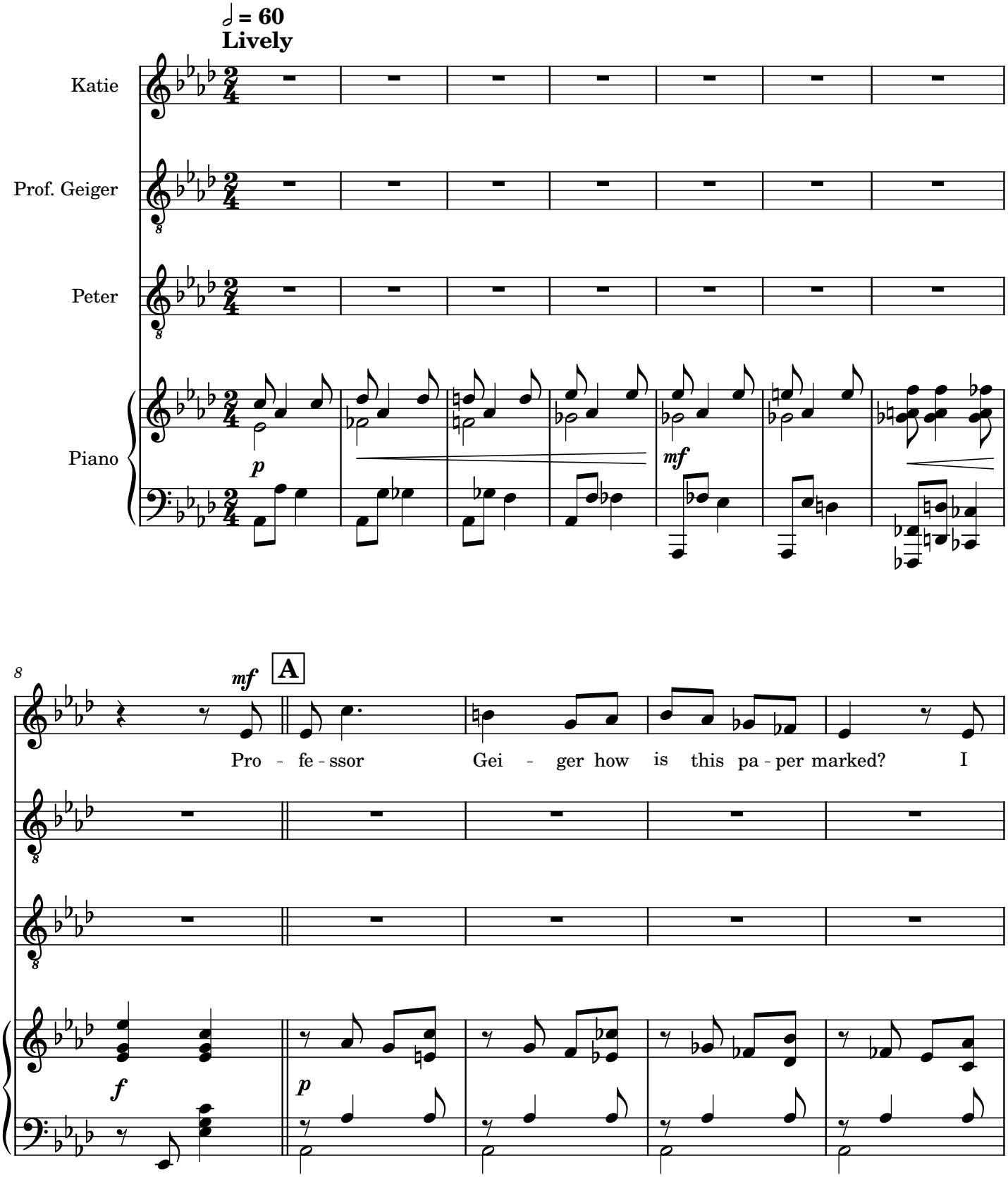

163
E
Ho - nes - tly, we should ask the prof - fe - sor, he's the
Ho - nes - tly, let's go ask the prof - fe - sor, he's the
Ped. Ped. Ped. Ped.
168
one with the o - fi - cial an - swer. Ho - nes - tly, we should ask the
one with the o - fi - cial an - swer. Ho - nes - tly, we should ask the
Ped. Ped. Ped.
174
prof. You're most - ly here to fa - cil - li - tate dis - cu - sion.
prof. I'm most - ly here to fa - cil - li - tate dis - cu - sion

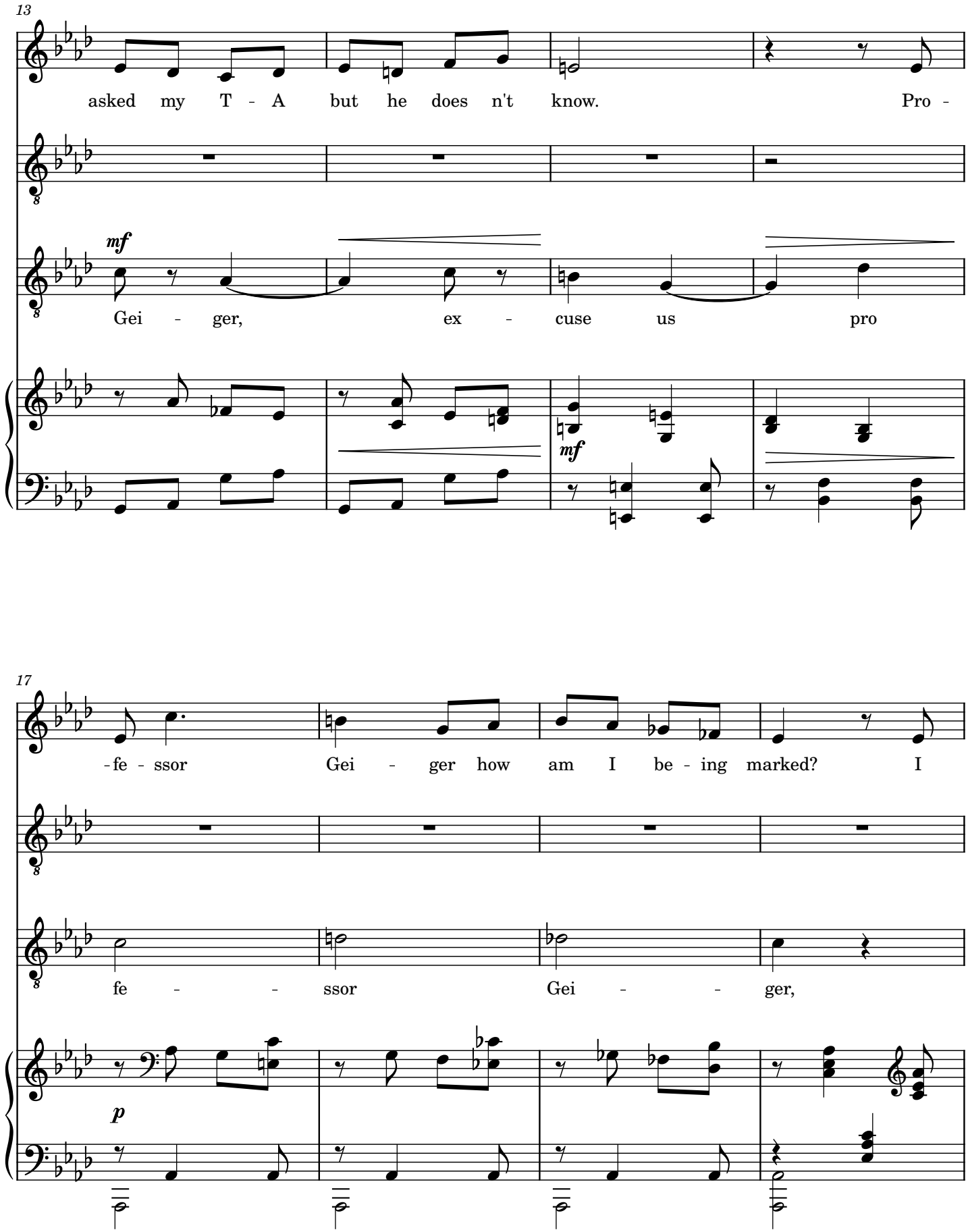

179
Your most - ly here to fa - cil - li - tate dis - cu - ssion, let's go
let's just go ask the prof ask the
183
ask the prof right now.
prof right - now!
187

No. 3. Finale.

"How is it marked?!"

Kevin Tran




13
asked my T - A but he does n't know. Pro -
mf
Gei - ger, ex - cuse us pro
mf
17
-fe - ssor Gei - ger how am I be - ing marked? I
fe - - ssor Gei - - ger,
p

21

a - sked Pe - ter, but he doe - - esn't

we need to know right now. Pro -

f

f

25

mp

know.

-fe - ssor Gei - ger how is this pa - per marked? My

29

I need to know Pro -

stu - dent asked me and I do not know. Pro -

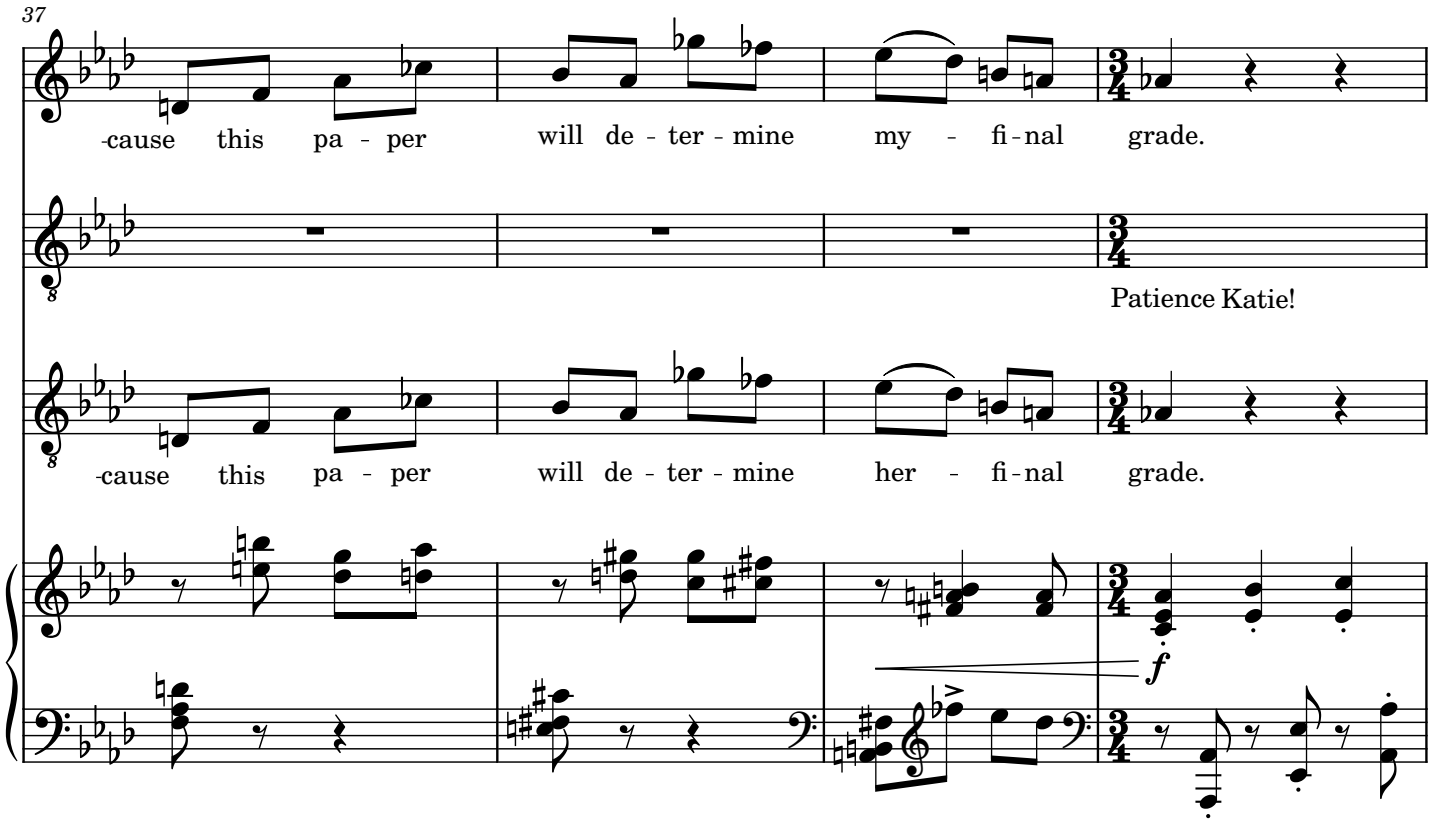
33

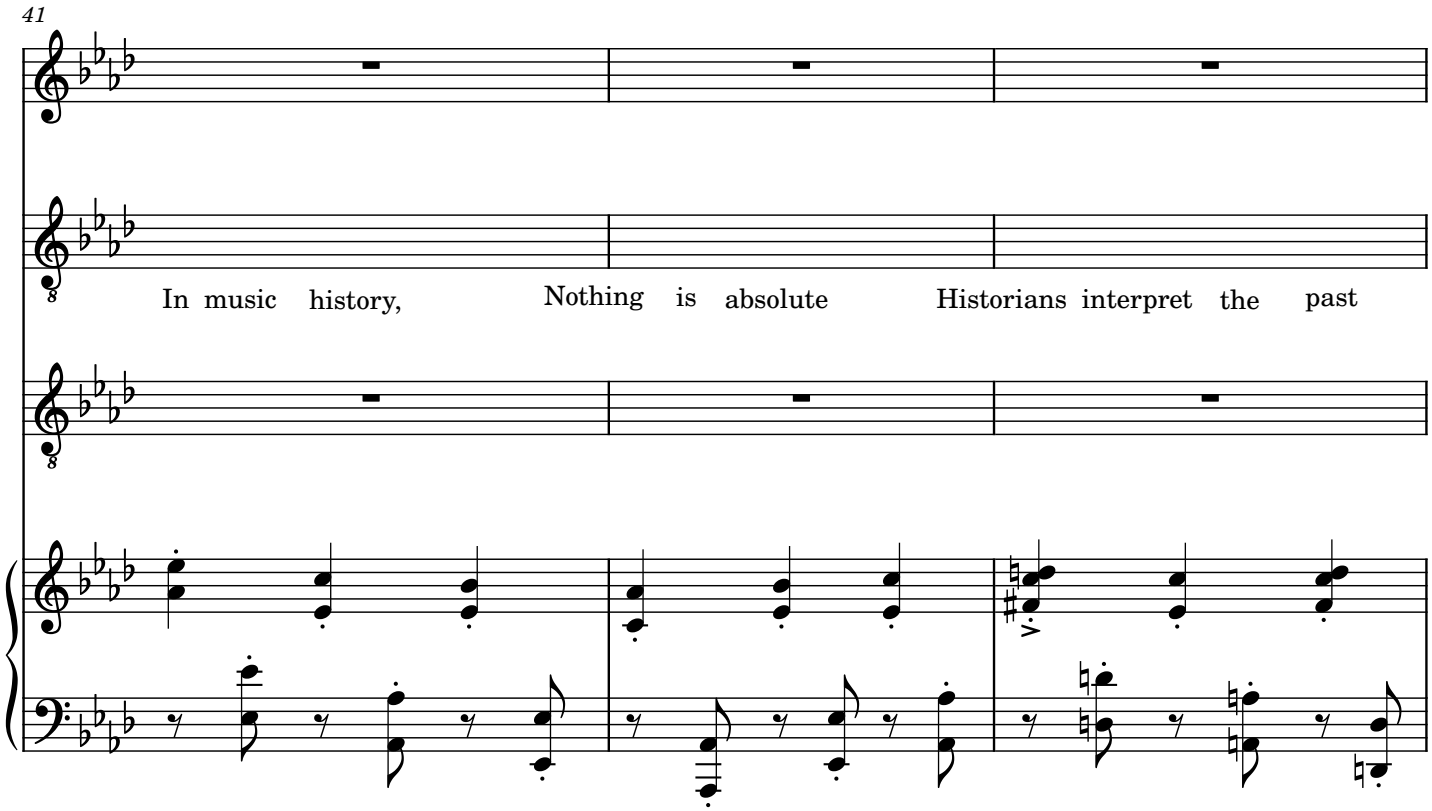
f

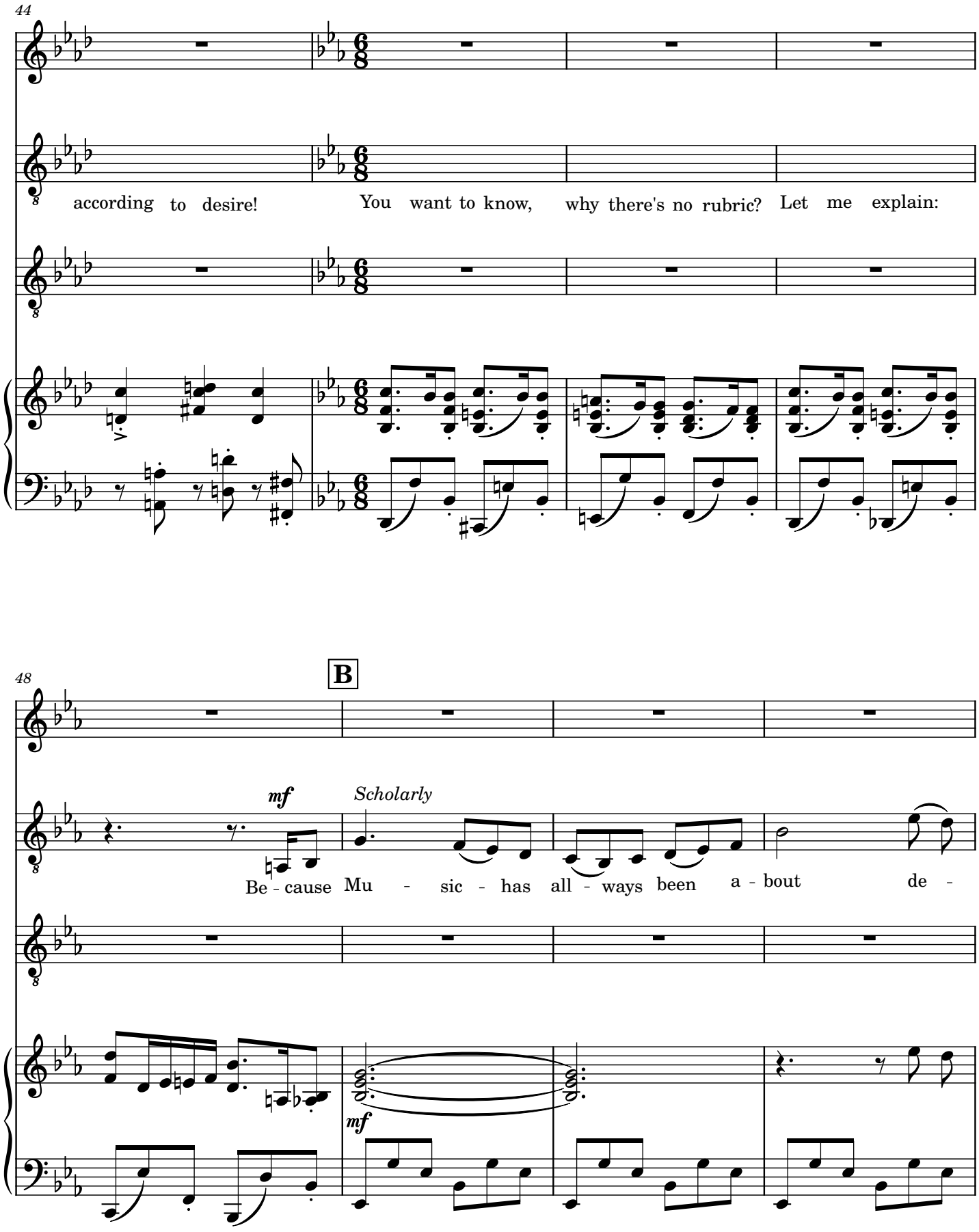
-fe - ssor Gei - ger I rea - lly go - tta know, be -

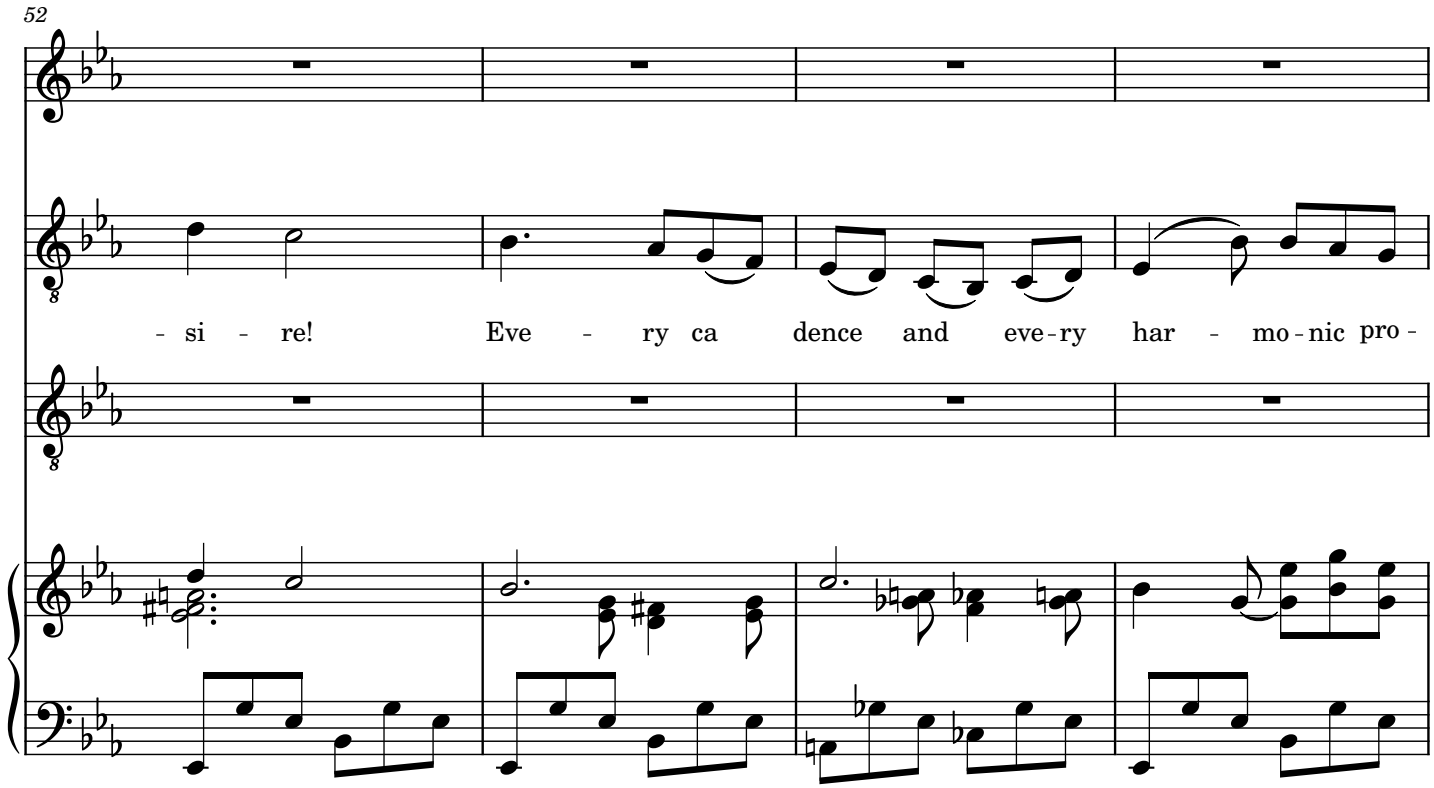
-fe - ssor Gei - ger we thought it fair to ask, be -

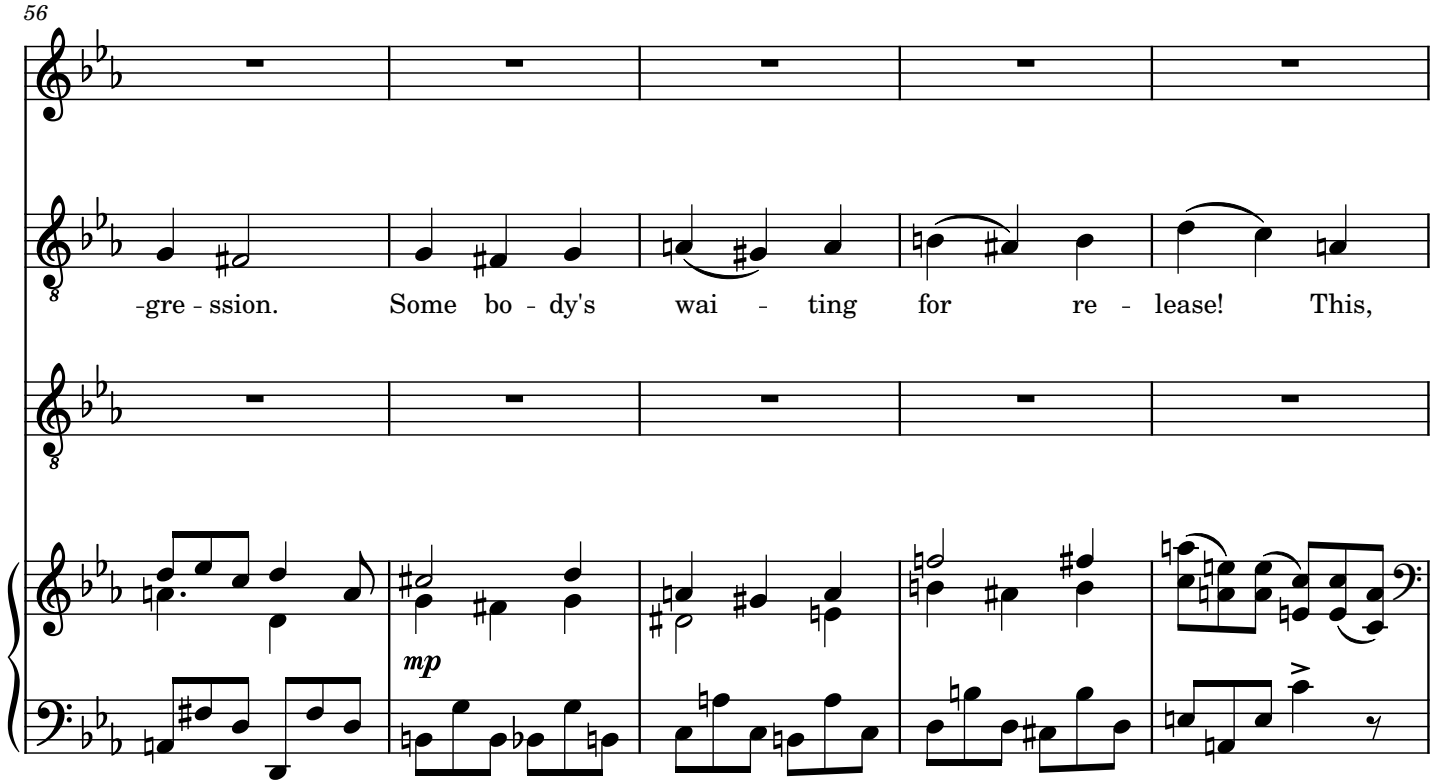
mp

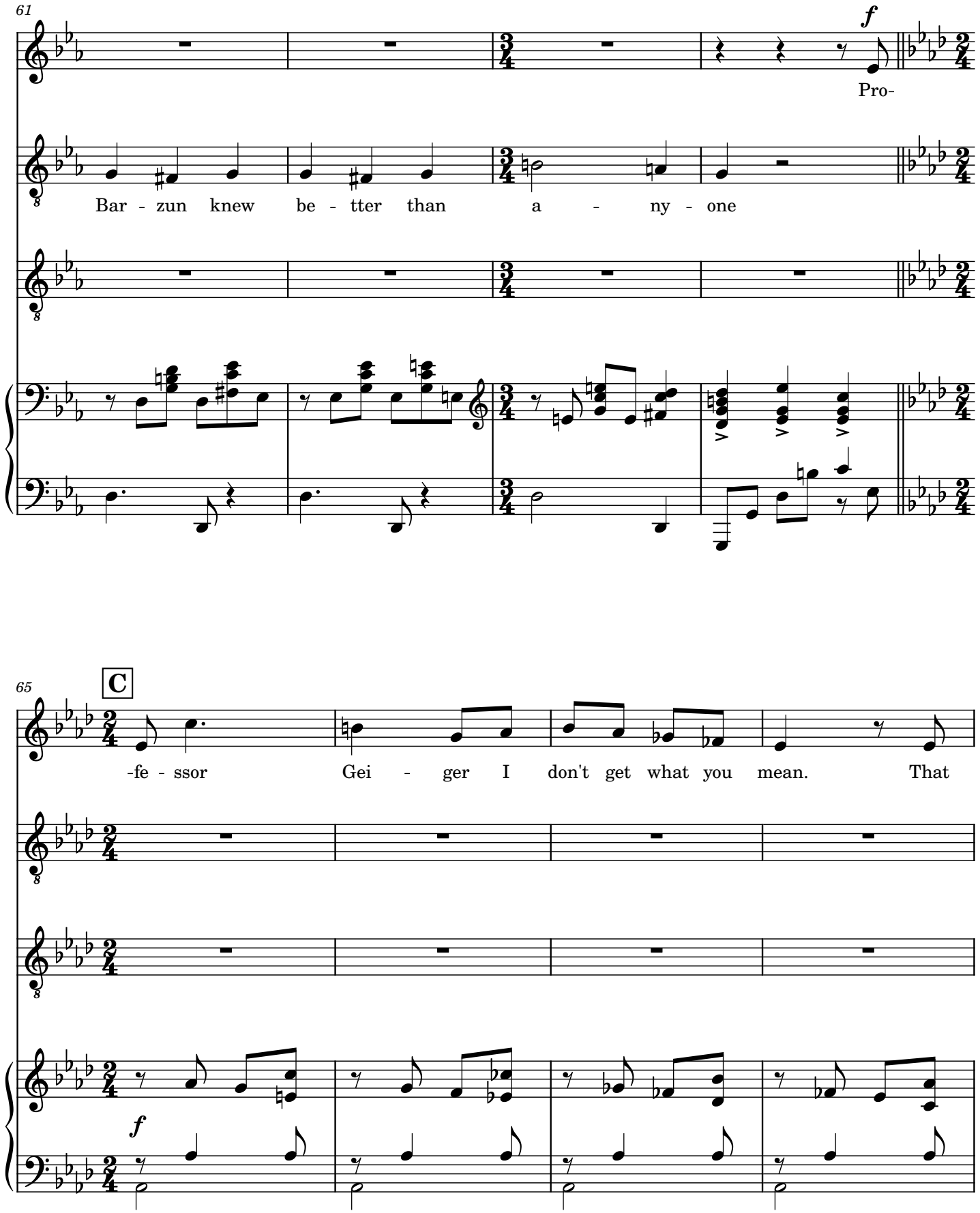

37
-cause this pa - per will de - ter - mine my - fi - nal grade.
Patience Katie!
-cause this pa - per will de - ter - mine her - fi - nal grade.
f

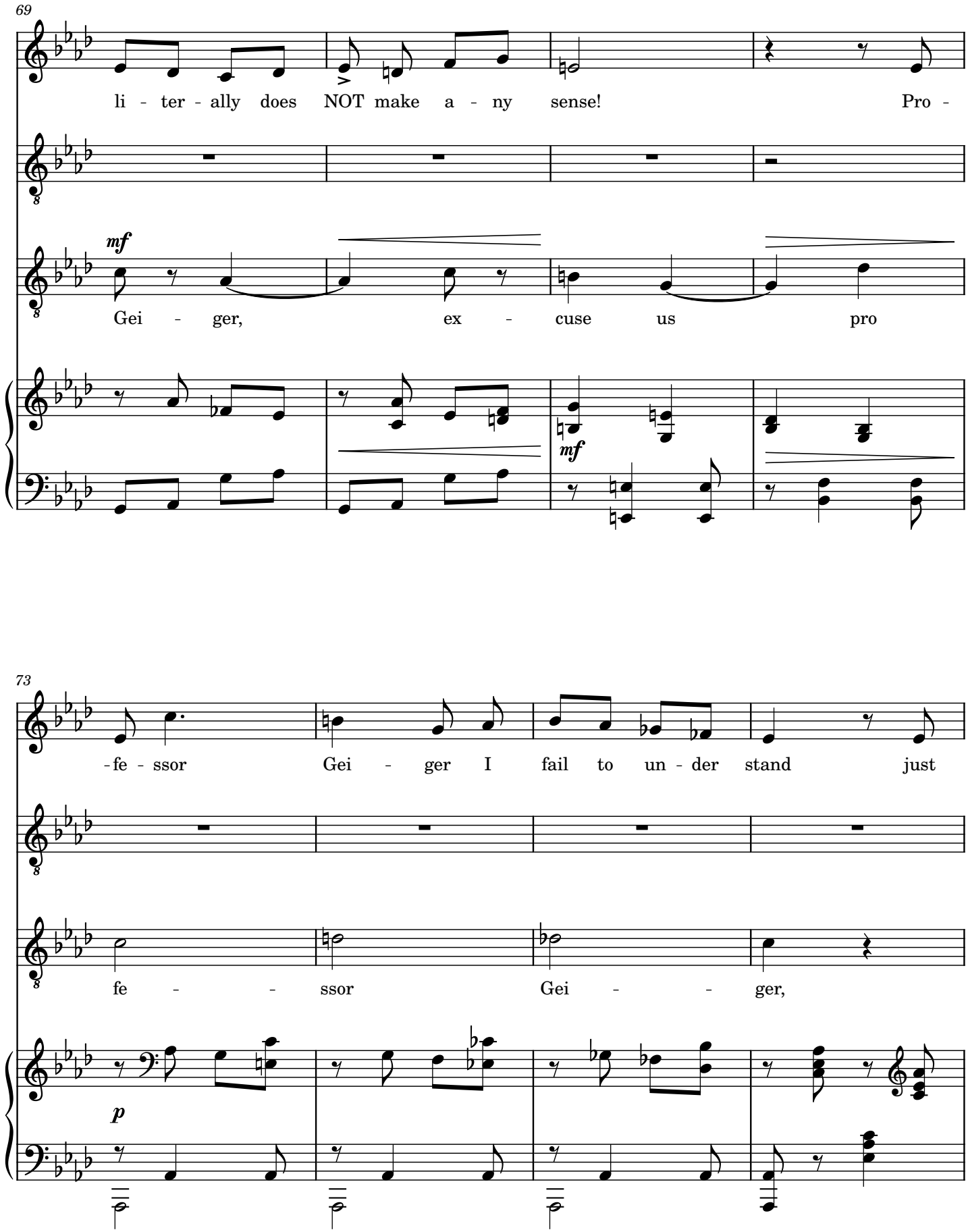

41
In music history, Nothing is absolute Historians interpret the past

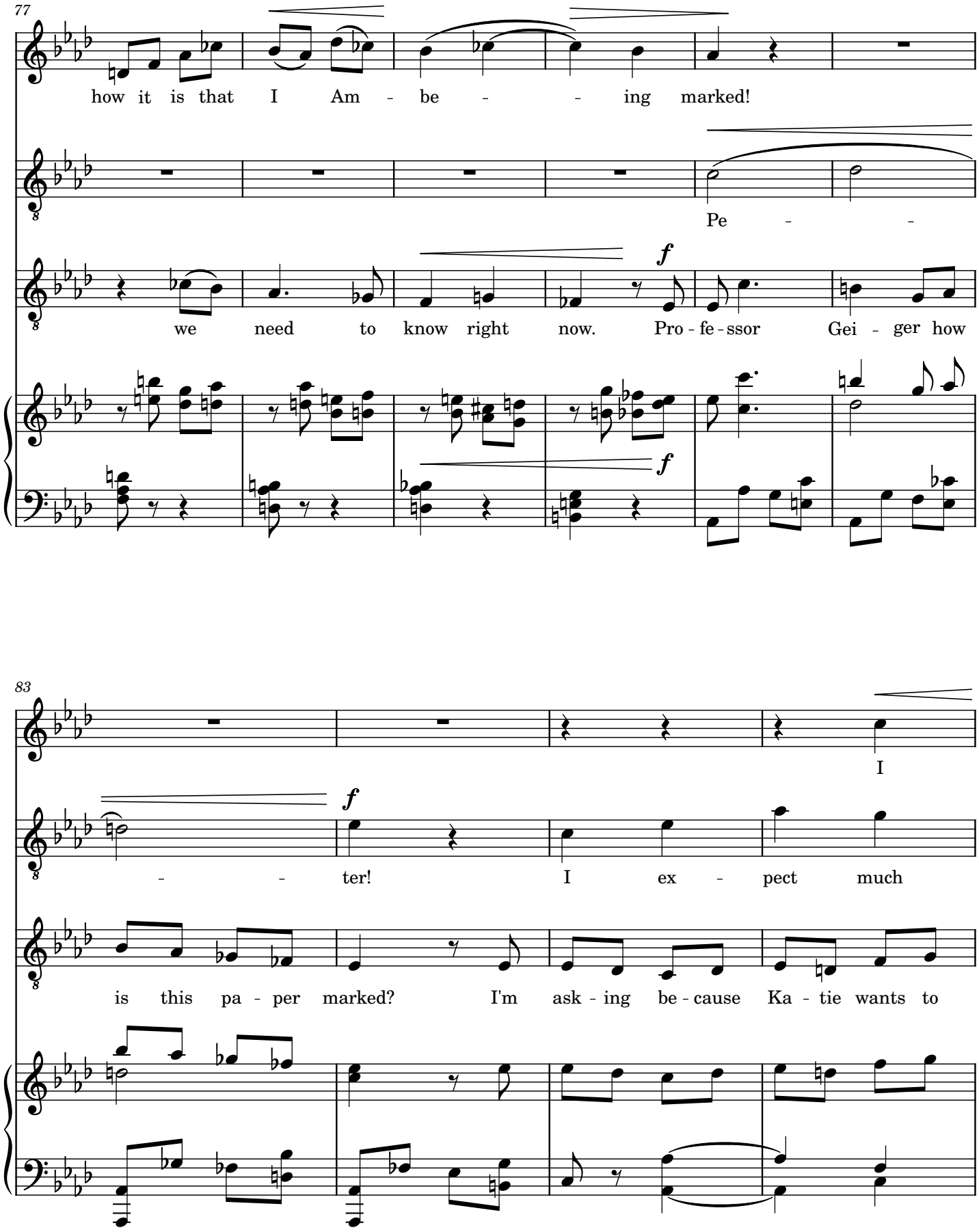

44
according to desire!
You want to know, why there's no rubric? Let me explain:
48
B
mf
Scholarly
Be - cause Mu - sic - has all - ways been a - bout de -
mf

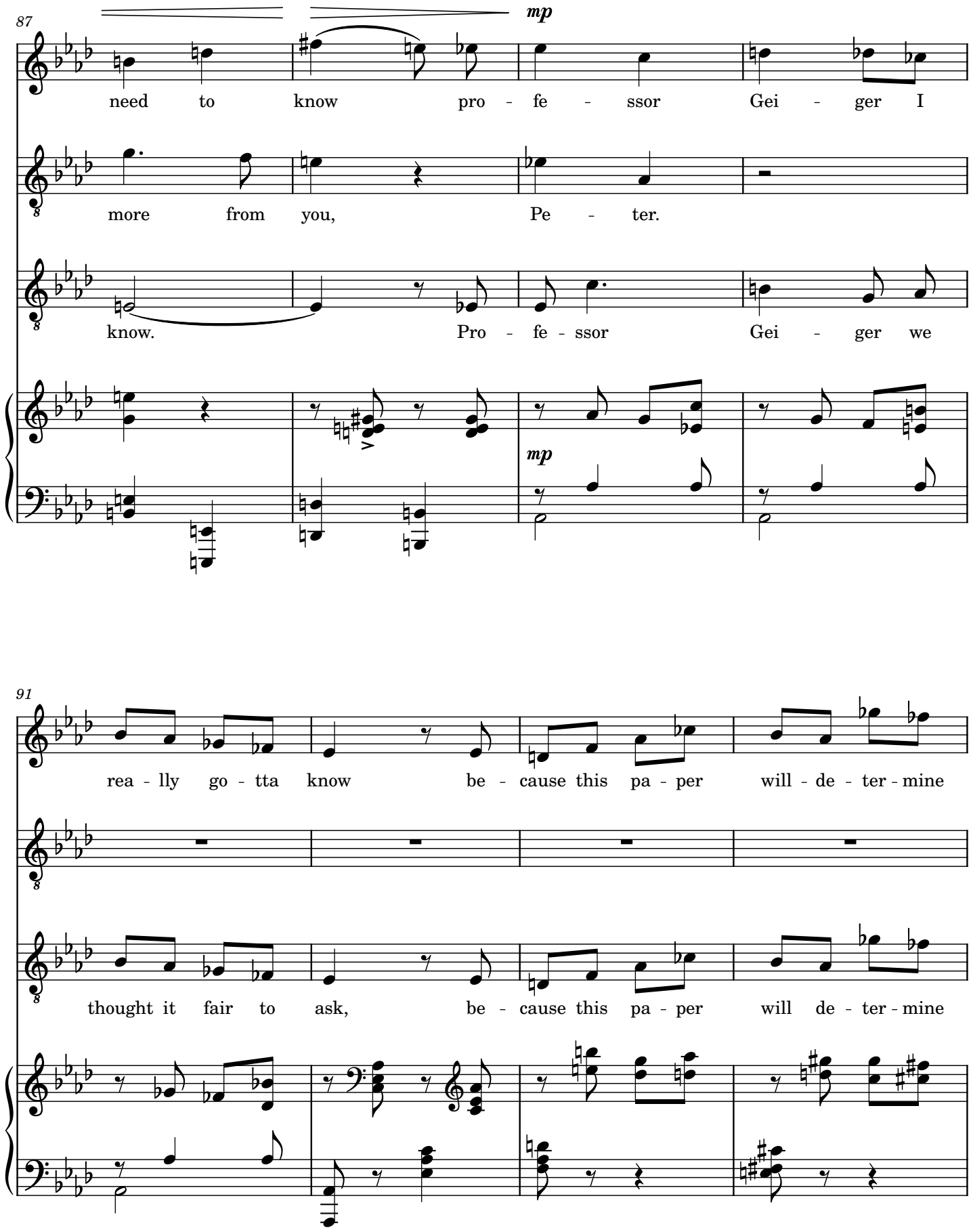

52
- si - re! Eve - ry ca dence and eve-ry har - mo-nic pro -

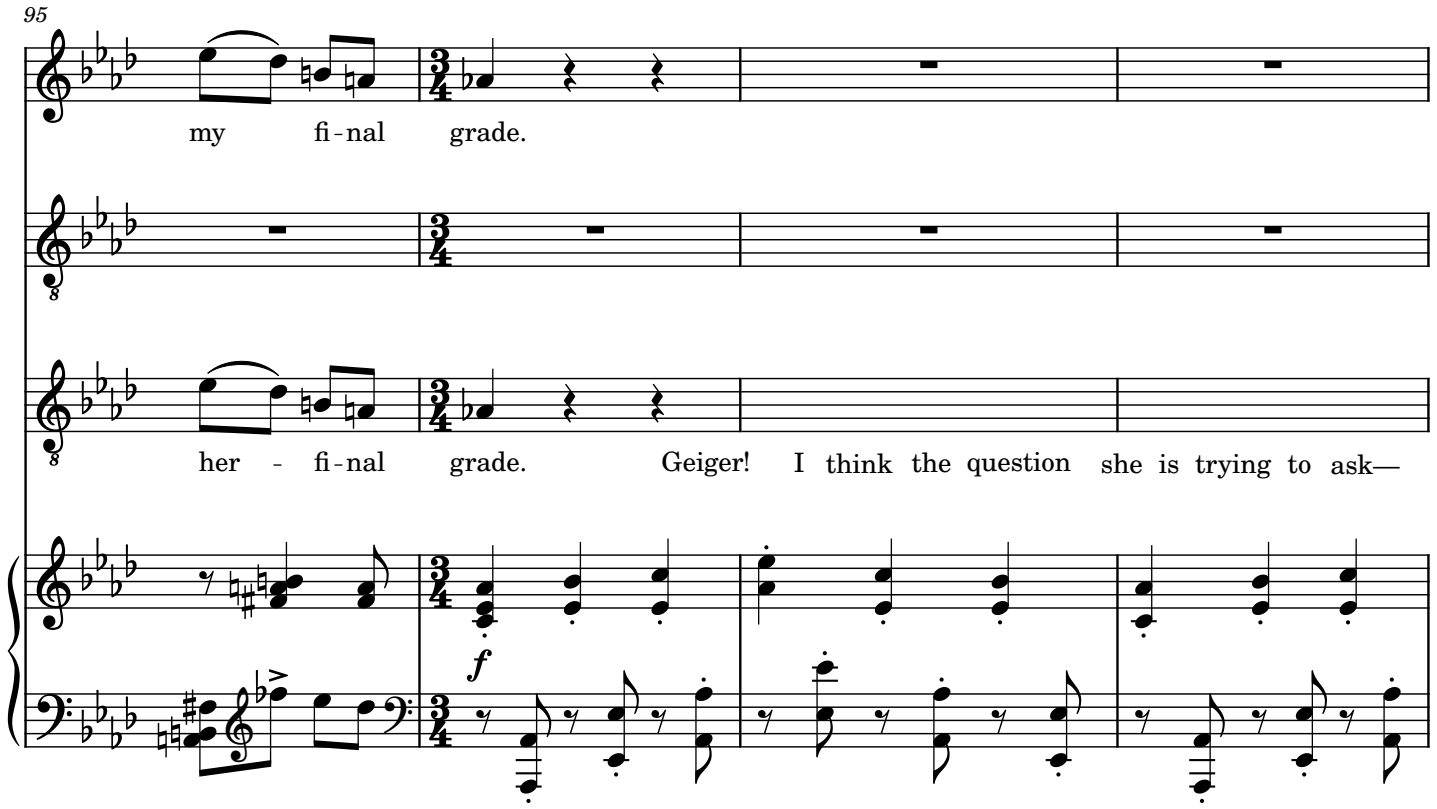

56
-gre - ssion. Some bo - dy's wai - ting for re - lease! This,
mp

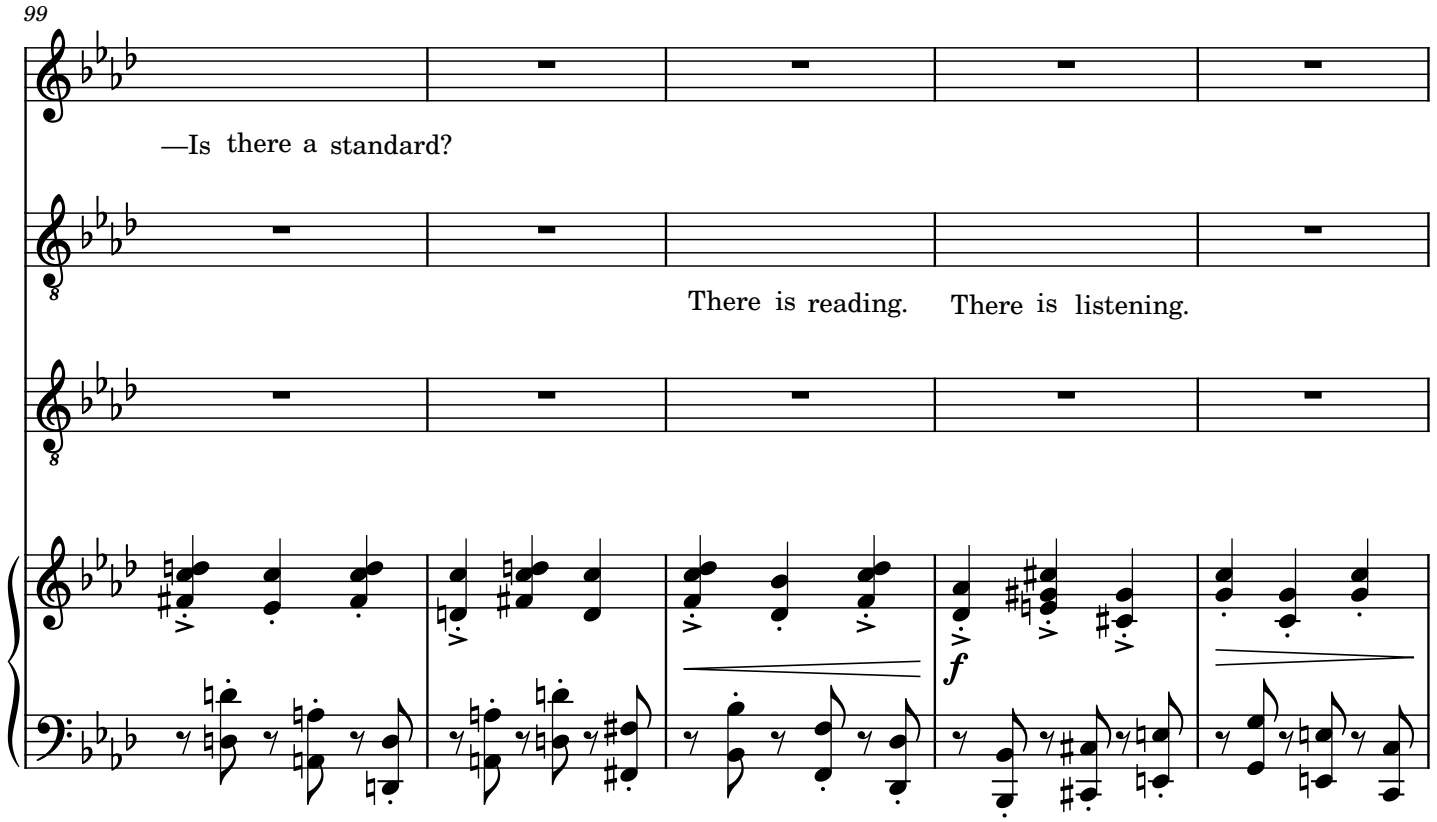

61
f
Pro-
Bar - zun knew be - tter than a - ny - one
65
C
-fe - ssor Gei - ger I don't get what you mean. That
f

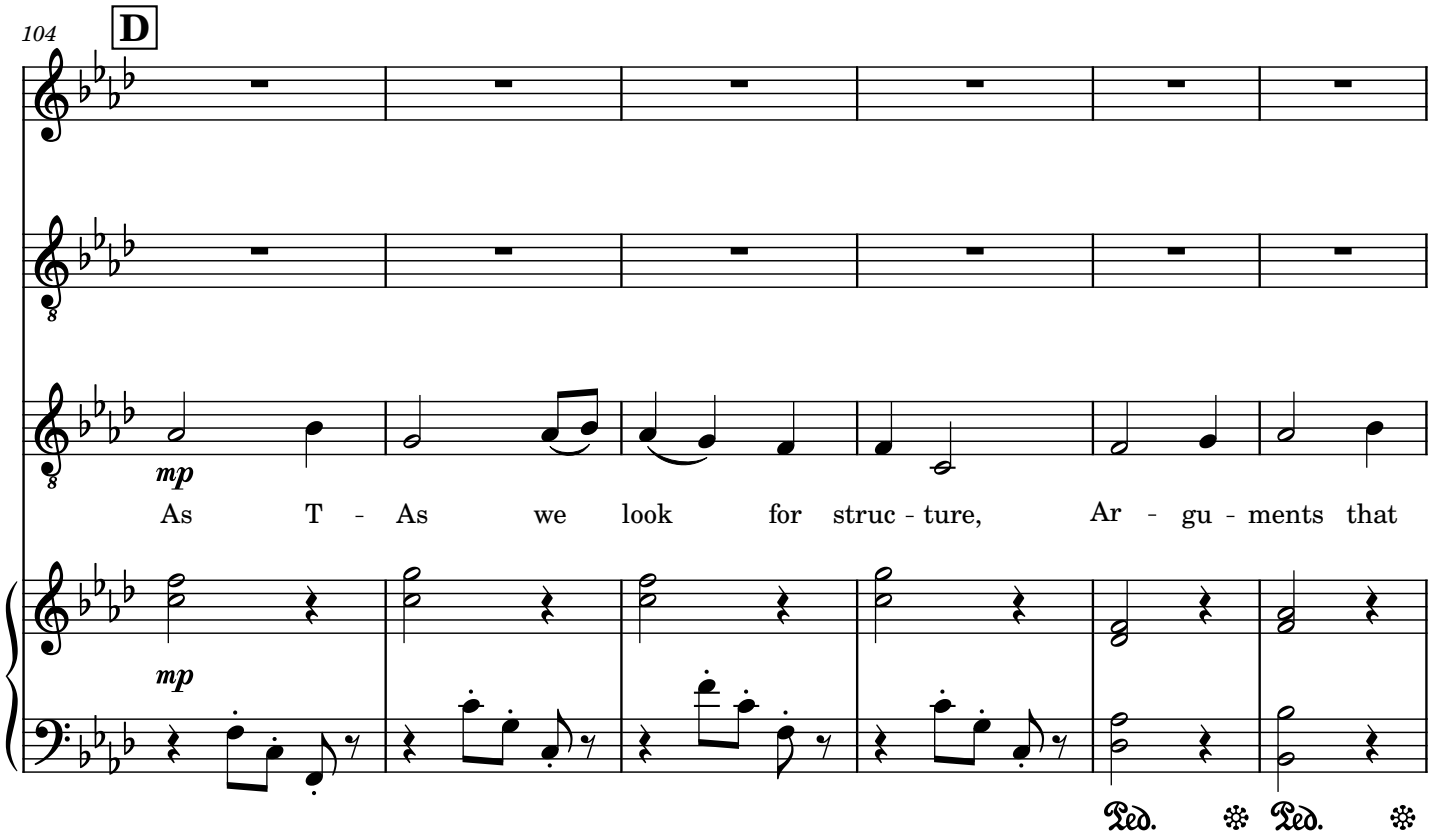

69
li - ter - ally does NOT make a - ny sense! Pro -
mf
Gei - ger, ex - cuse us pro
mf
73
-fe - ssor Gei - ger I fail to un - der stand just
fe - - ssor Gei - - ger,
p

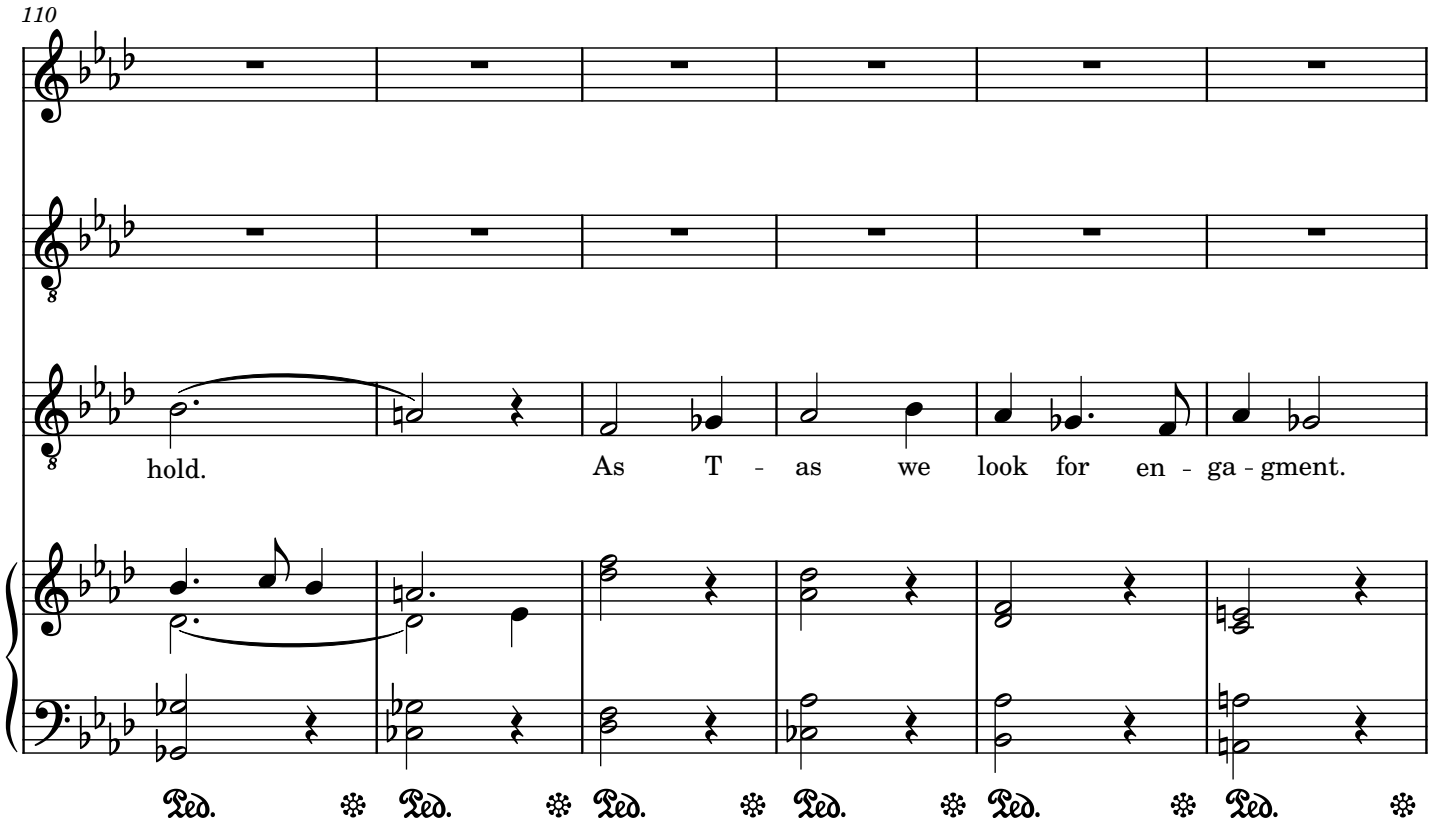

77
how it is that I Am - be - - ing marked!
Pe - -
we need to know right now. Pro - fe - ssor Gei - ger how
f
f
83
I
- - ter! I ex - pect much
f
is this pa - per marked? I'm ask - ing be - cause Ka - tie wants to

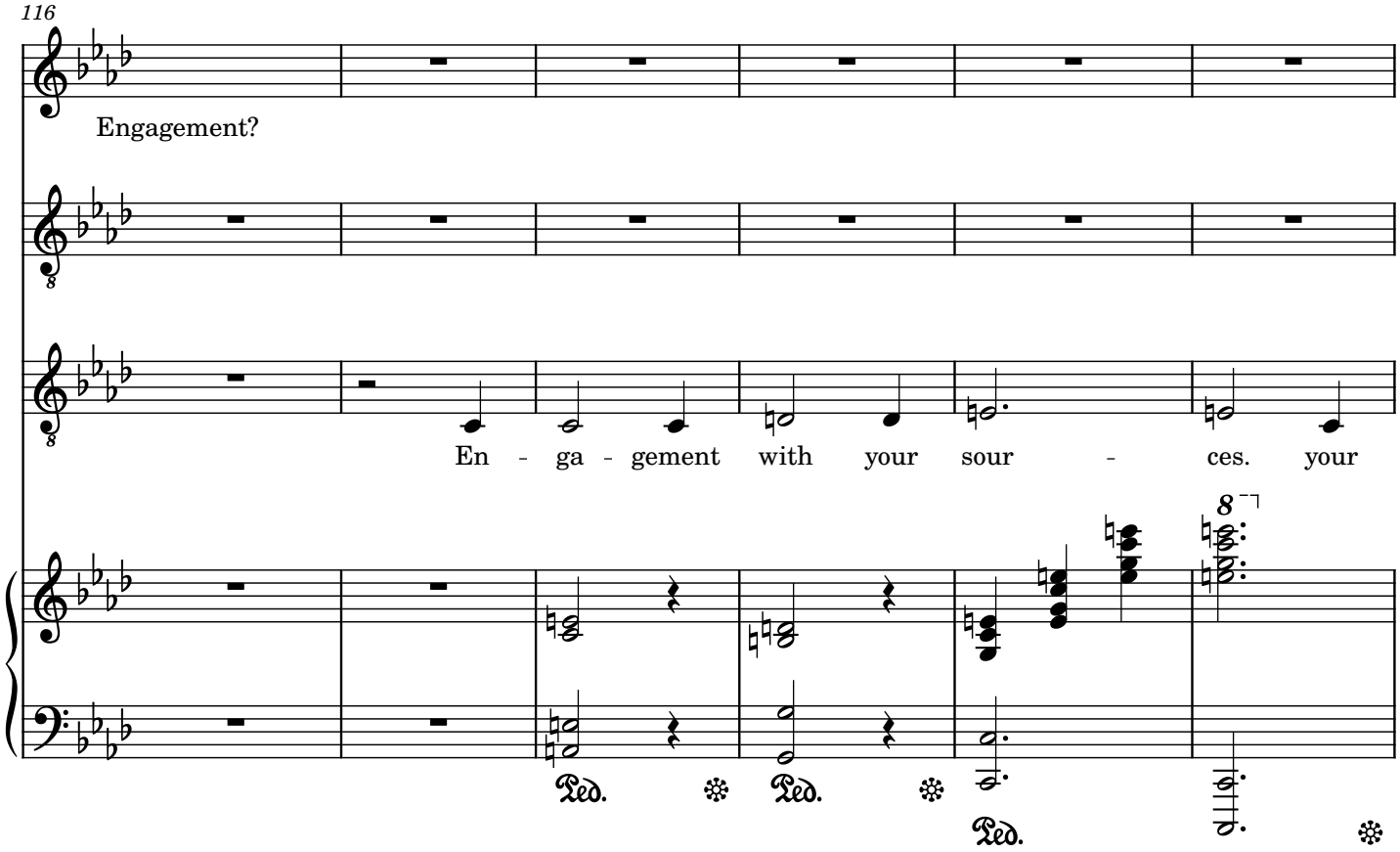

87
mp
need to know pro - fe - ssor Gei - ger I
more from you, Pe - ter.
know. Pro - fe - ssor Gei - ger we
mp
91
rea - lly go - tta know be - cause this pa - per will - de - ter - mine
thought it fair to ask, be - cause this pa - per will de - ter - mine

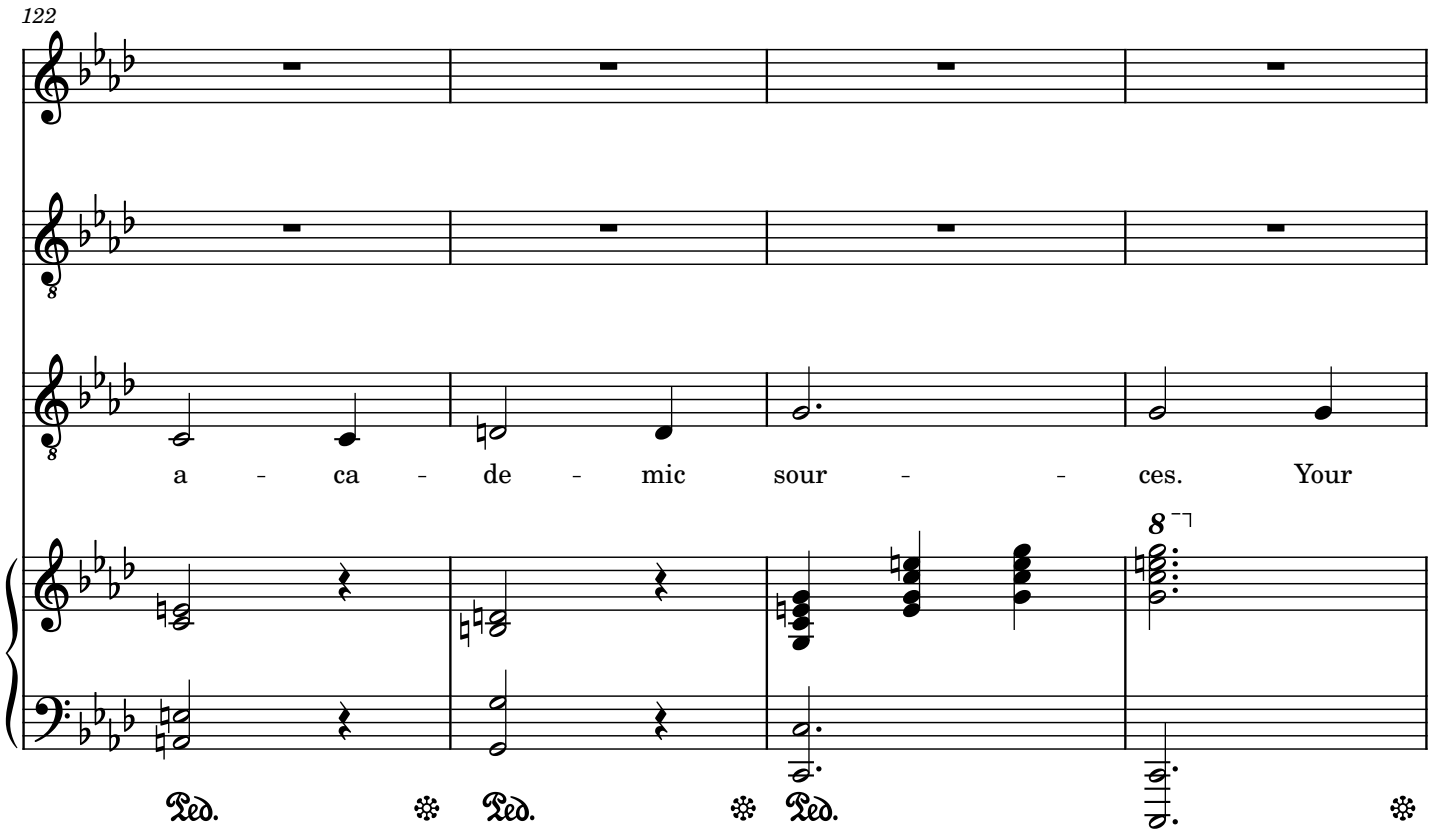

95
my fi-nal grade.
her - fi-nal grade. Geiger! I think the question she is trying to ask—
f


99
—Is there a standard?
There is reading. There is listening.
f


104
D
mp
As T - As we look for struc - ture, Ar - gu - ments that
mp
Ped. Ped.


110
hold. As T - as we look for en - ga - gment.
Ped. Ped. Ped. Ped. Ped. Ped.


116
Engagement?
En - ga - gement with your sour - ces. your
8
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.


122
a - ca - de - mic sour - - ces. Your
8
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.

126

a - ca - de - mic sour - ces And

Ped. Ped.

130

recit (interupting)

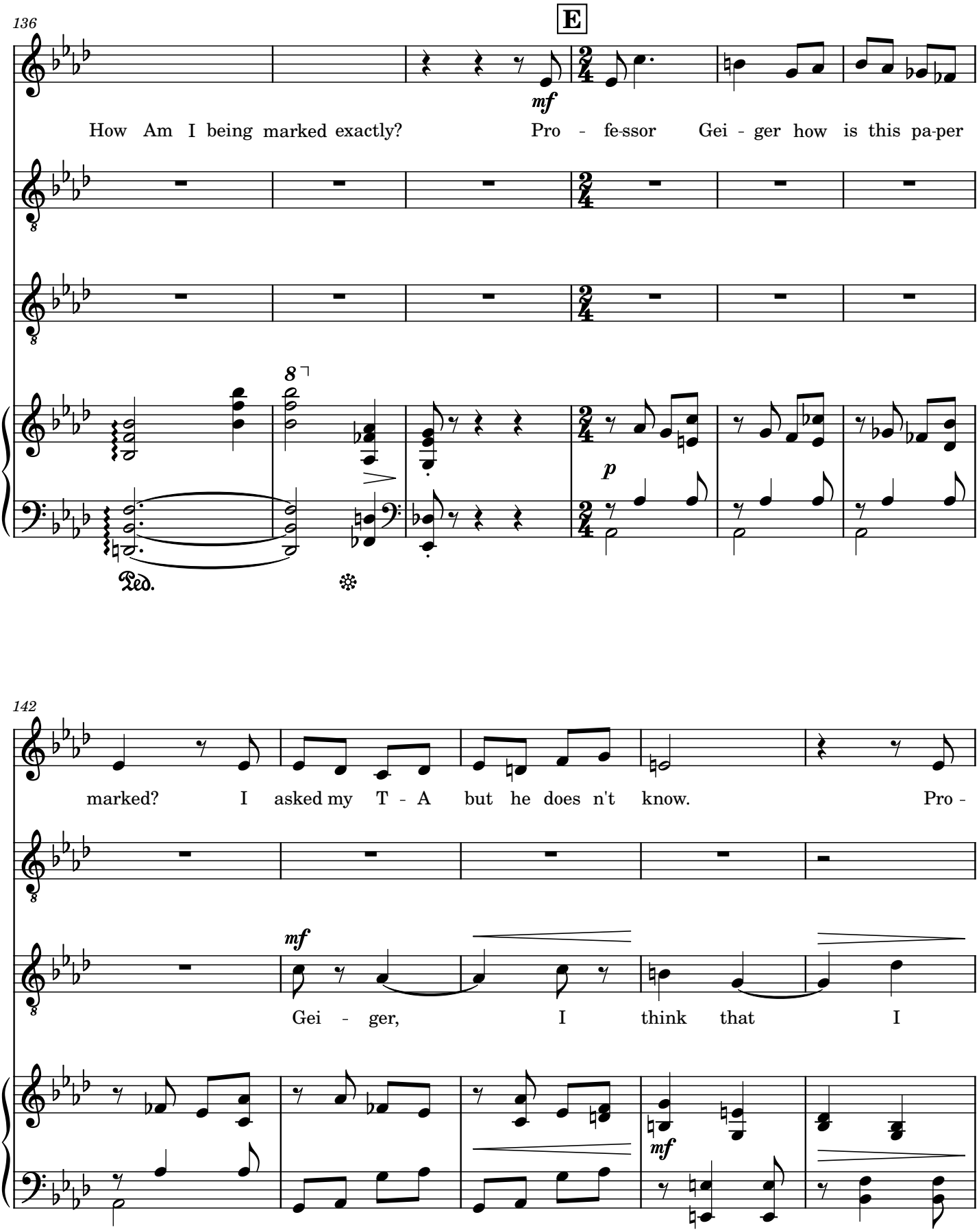
mp

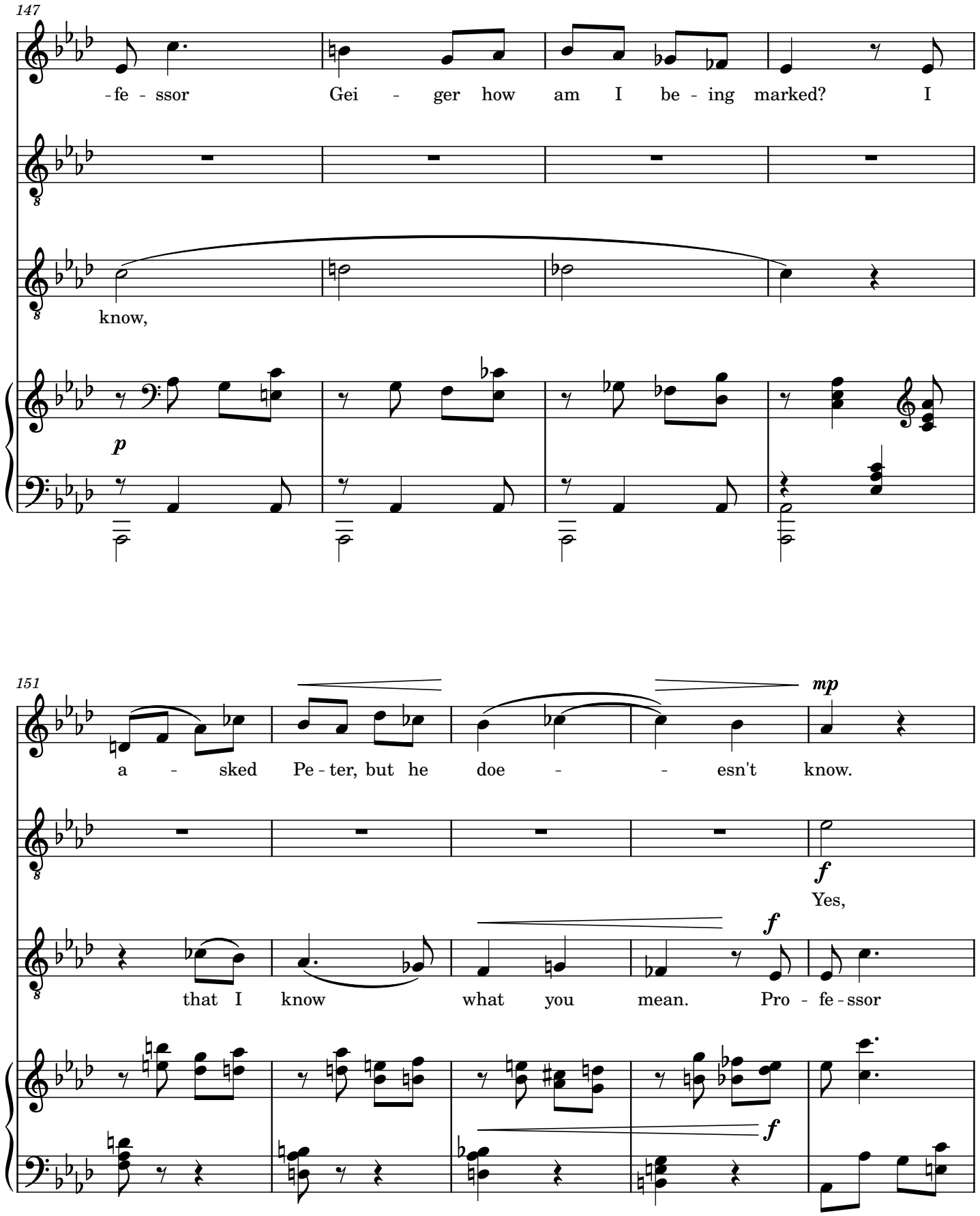
Cla - ri - ty can be emp - ty. Po - lish can lie.

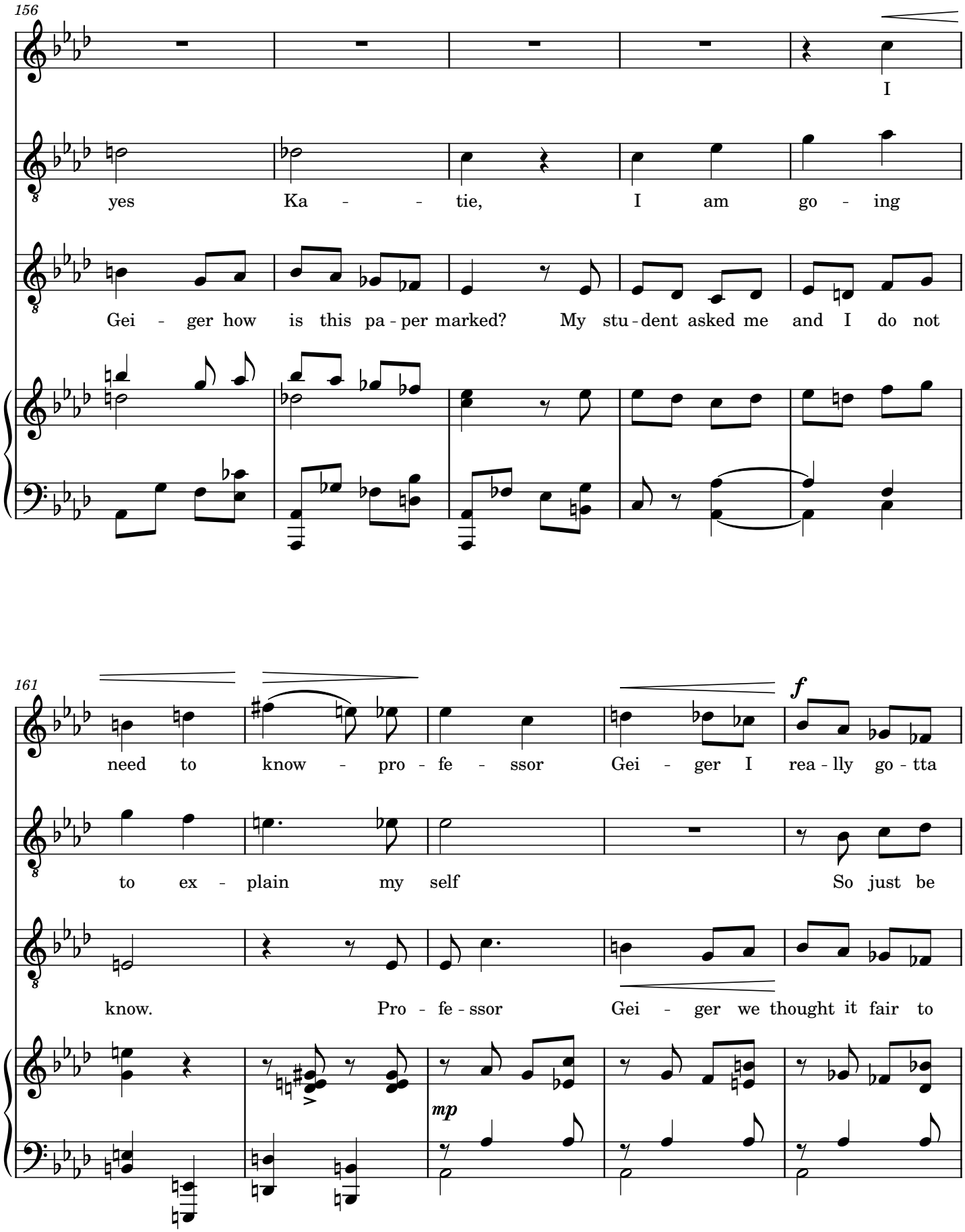
So...

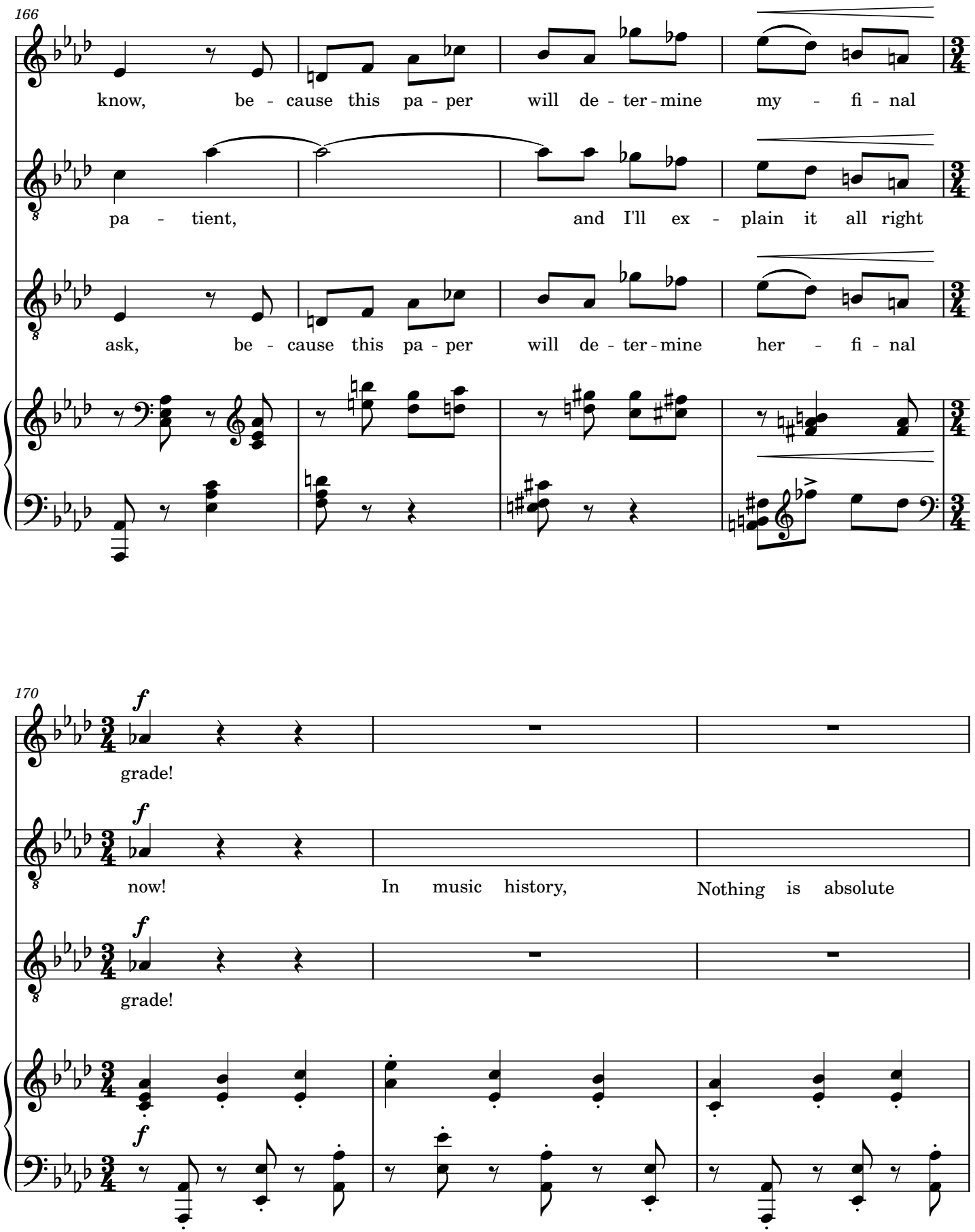
clarity—

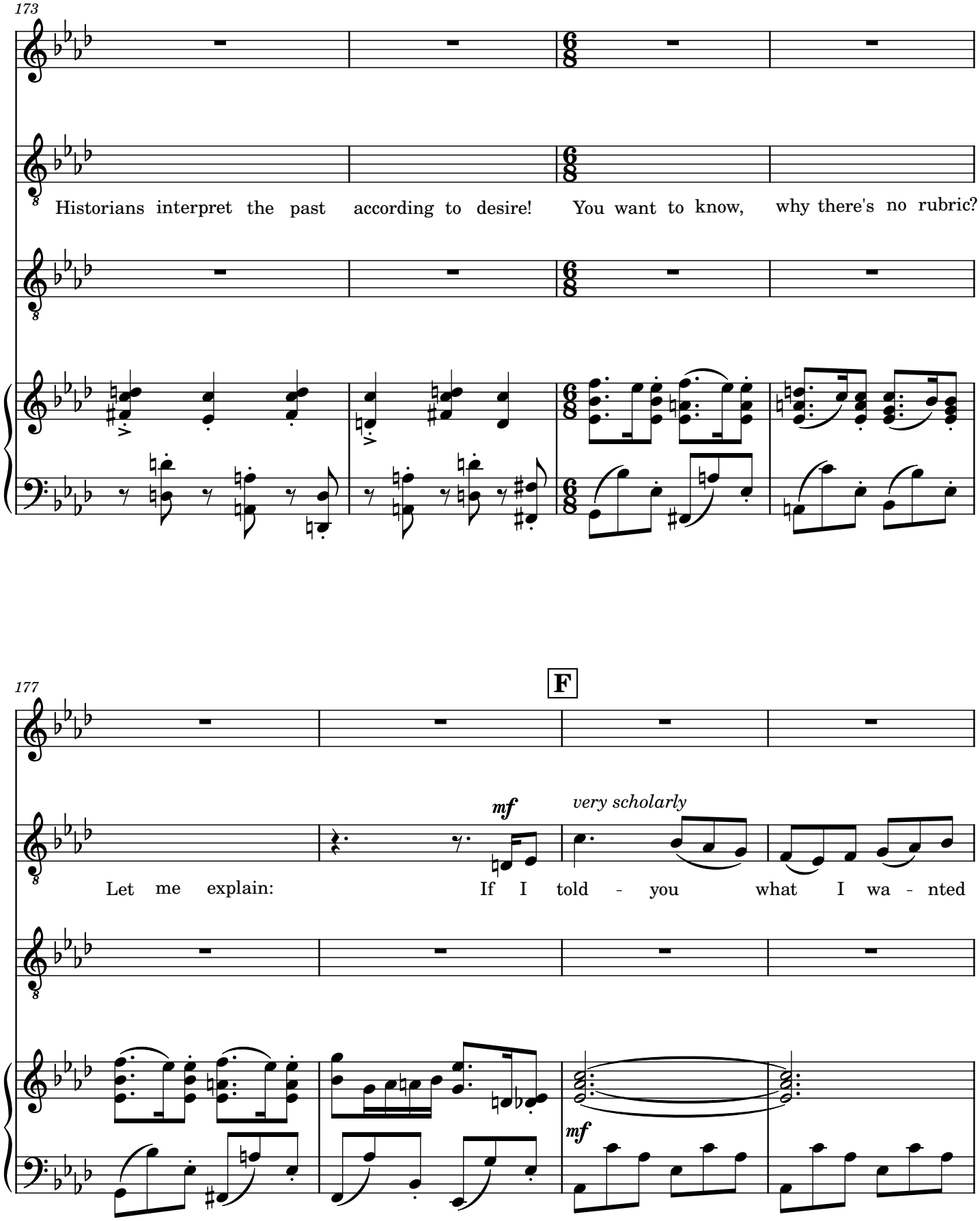
*Nods with uncertaintly

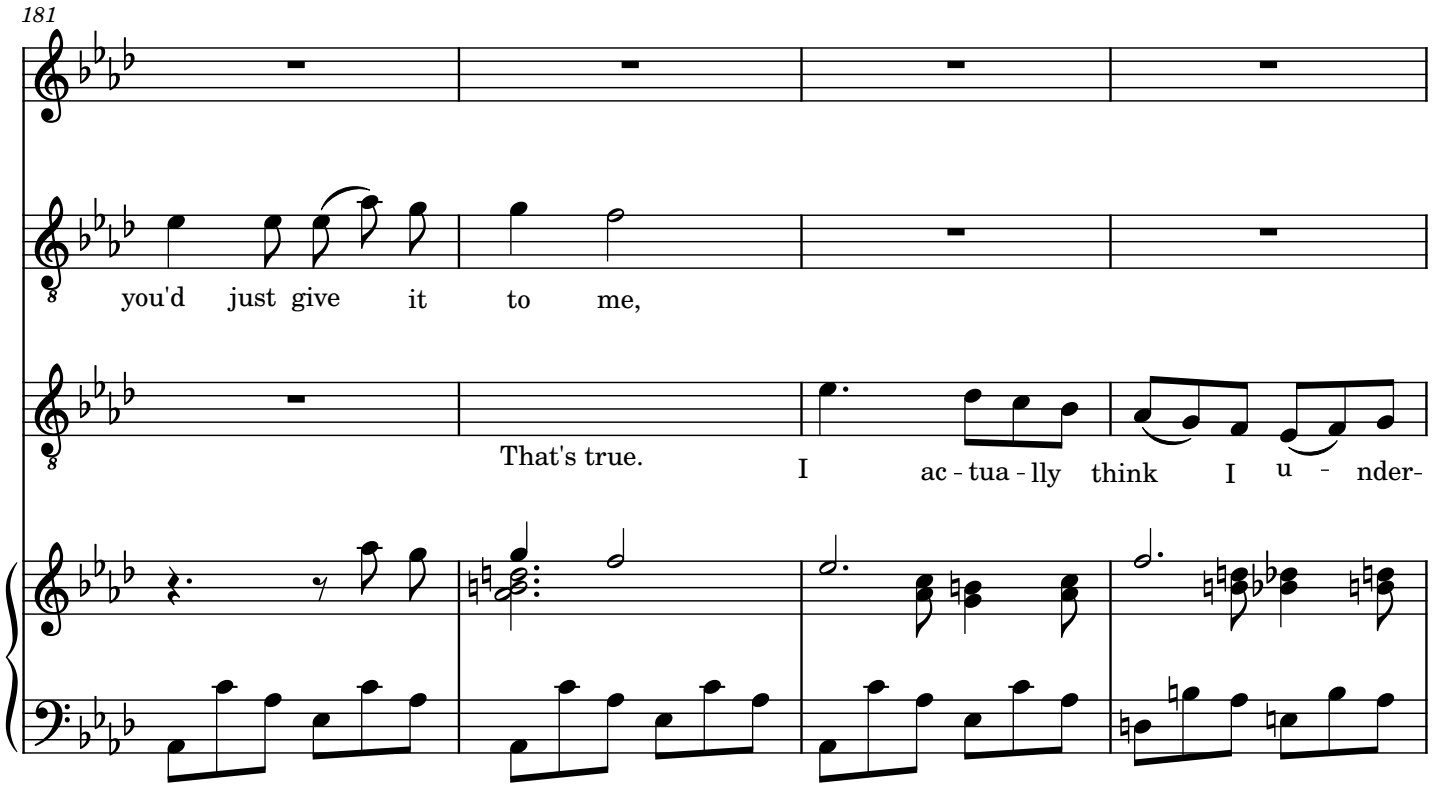

136
E
mf
How Am I being marked exactly? Pro - fe-ssor Gei - ger how is this pa-per
8
p
Ped.
142
marked? I asked my T - A but he does n't know. Pro -
mf
Gei - ger, I think that I
mf

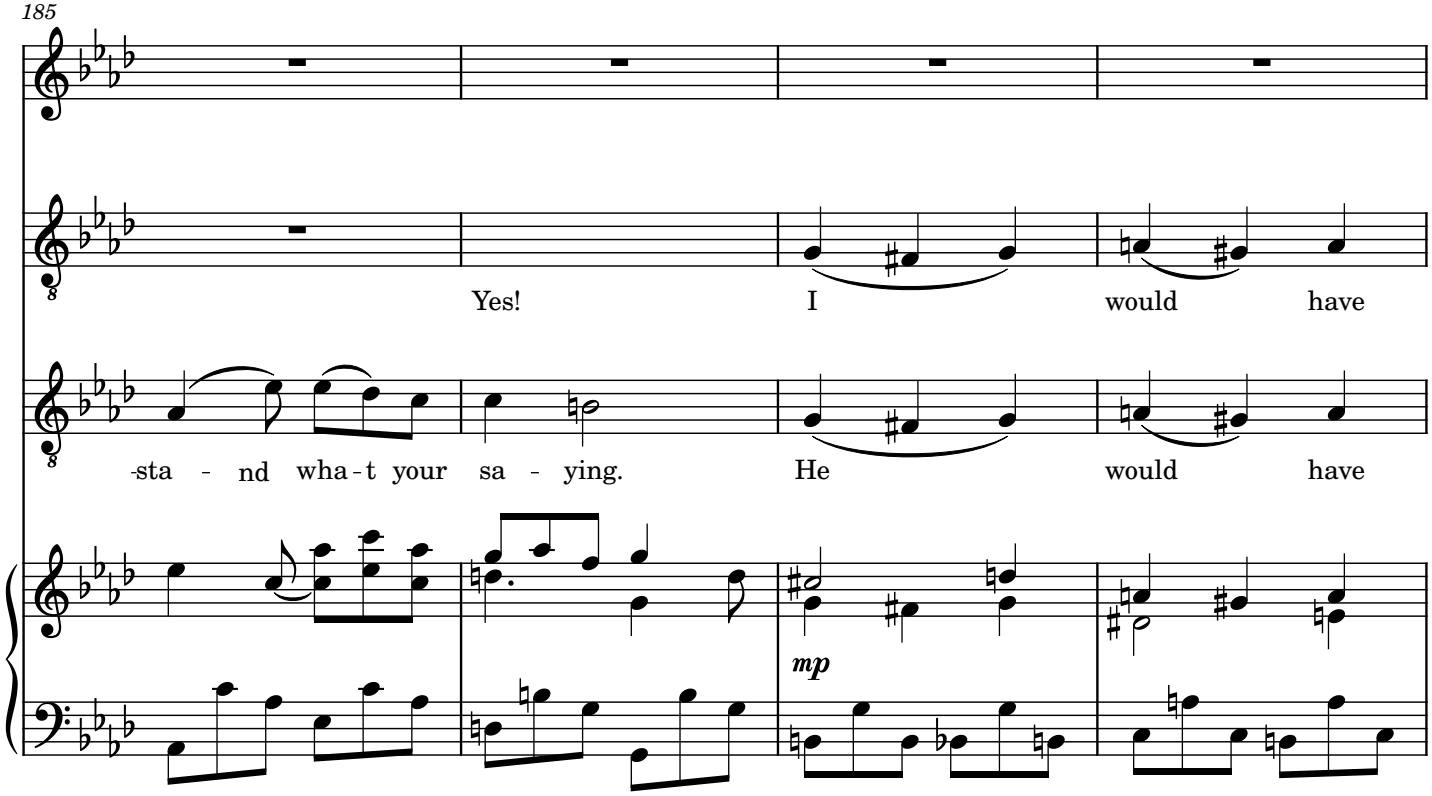

147
-fe - ssor Gei - ger how am I be - ing marked? I
know,
p
151
a - sked Pe - ter, but he doe - - esn't know.
mp
f
Yes,
that I know what you mean. Pro - fe - ssor
f
f

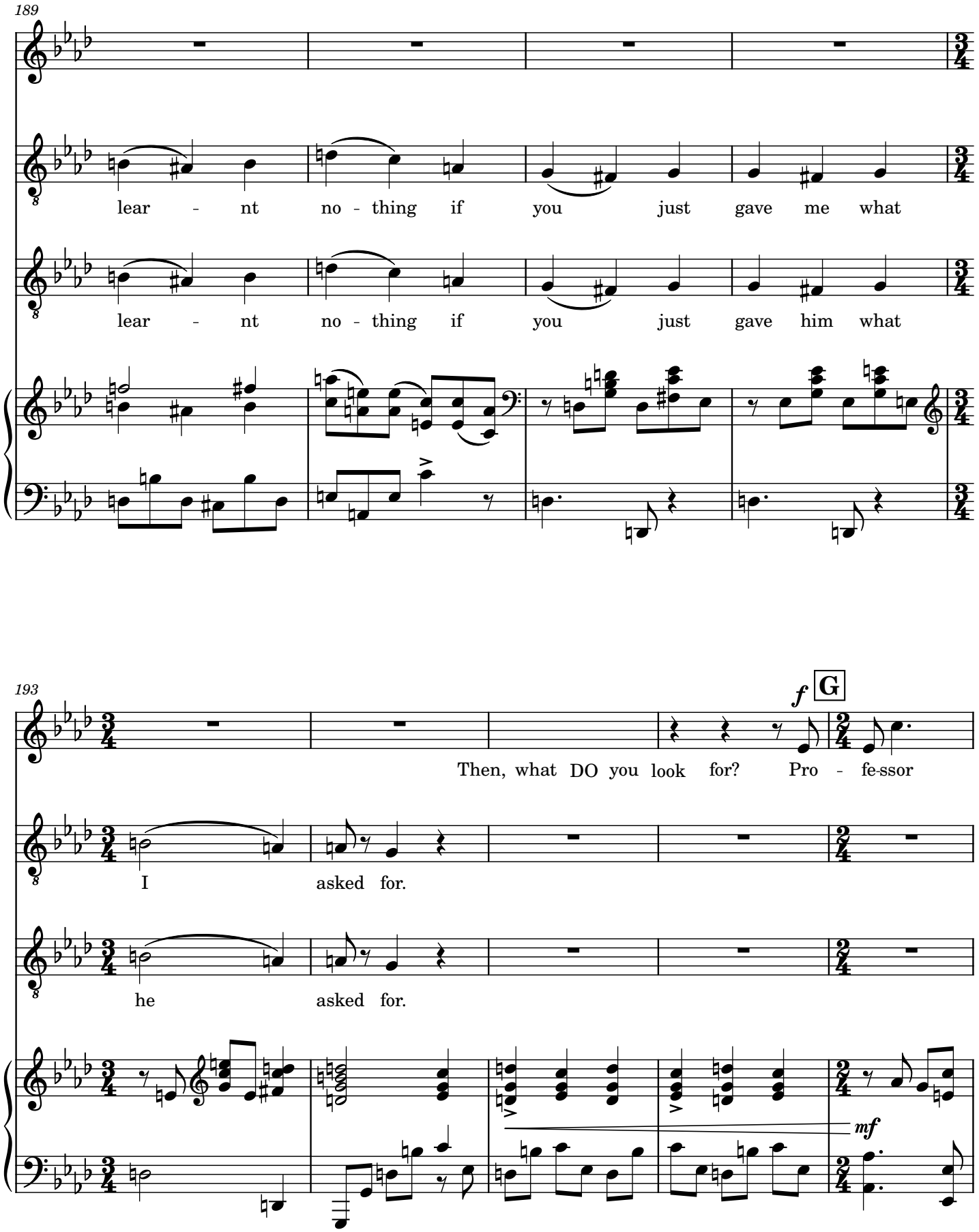

156
I
yes Ka - - tie, I am go - ing
Gei - ger how is this pa - per marked? My stu - dent asked me and I do not
161
need to know - pro - fe - ssor Gei - ger I rea - lly go - tta
f
to ex - plain my self So just be
know. Pro - fe - ssor Gei - ger we thought it fair to
mp

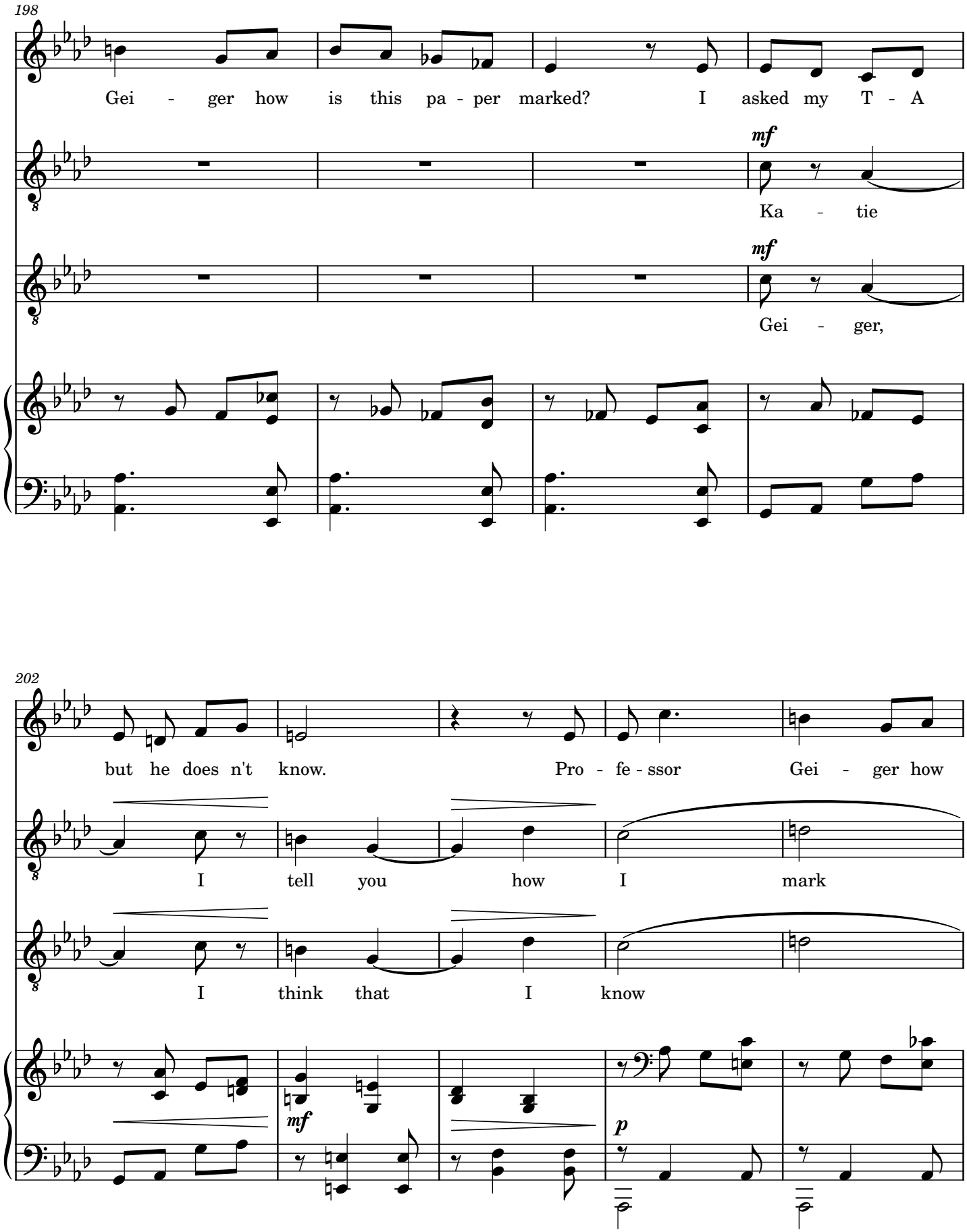

166
know, be - cause this pa - per will de - ter - mine my - fi - nal
pa - tient, and I'll ex - plain it all right
ask, be - cause this pa - per will de - ter - mine her - fi - nal
170
f
grade!
now! In music history, Nothing is absolute
grade!

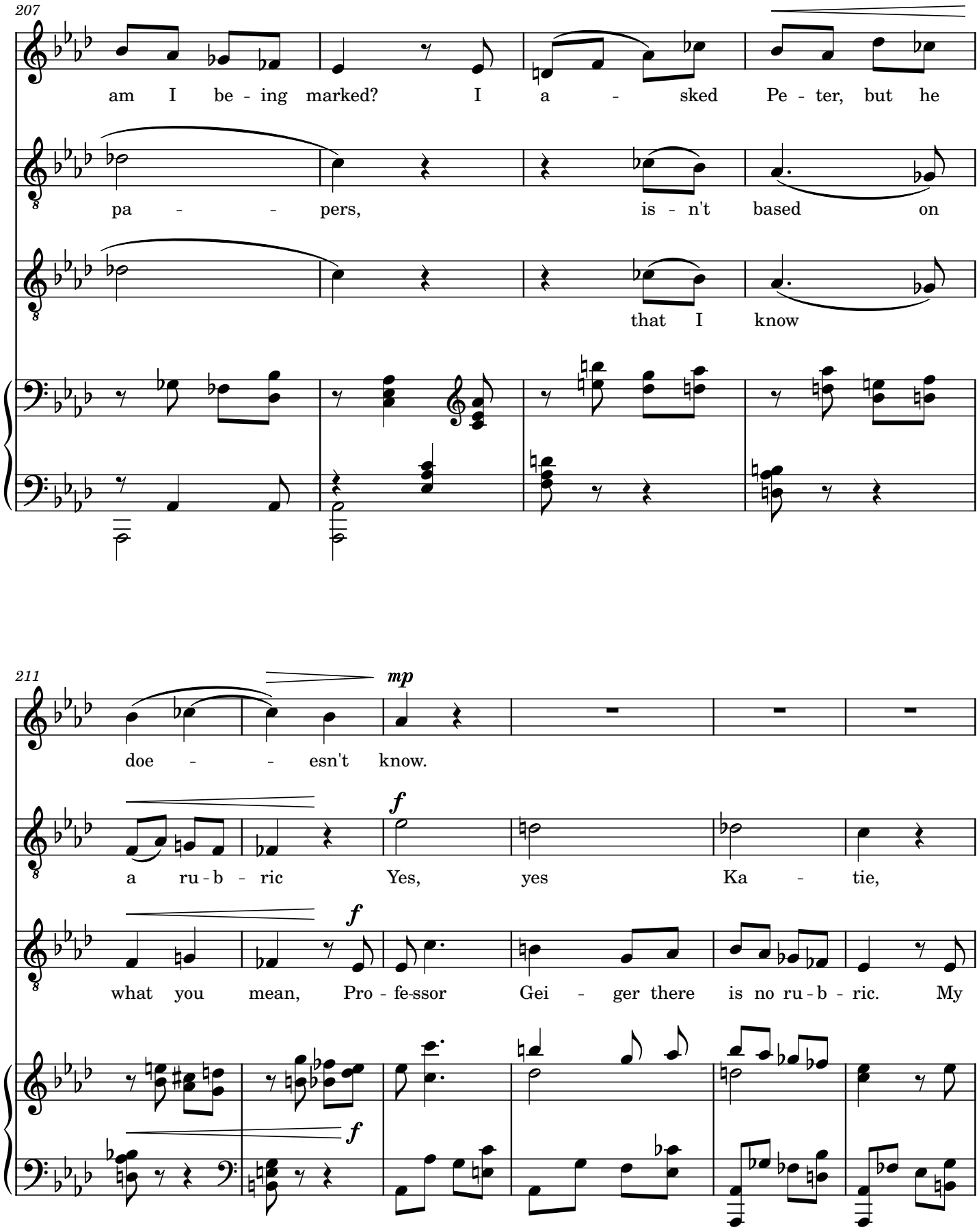

173
Historians interpret the past according to desire! You want to know, why there's no rubric?
177
F
mf
very scholarly
Let me explain: If I told - you what I wa - nted
mf


181
you'd just give it to me,
That's true.
I ac - tua - lly think I u - nder-


185
Yes! I would have
-sta - nd wha - t your sa - ying. He would have
mp


189
lear - nt no - thing if you just gave me what
lear - nt no - thing if you just gave him what
193
f
G
Then, what DO you look for? Pro - fe-ssor
I asked for.
he asked for.
mf


198
Gei - ger how is this pa - per marked? I asked my T - A
mf
Ka - tie
mf
Gei - ger,
202
but he does n't know. Pro - fe - ssor Gei - ger how
I tell you how I mark
I think that I know
mf
p


207
am I be - ing marked? I a - sked Pe - ter, but he
pa - - pers, is - n't based on
that I know
211
mp
doe - - esn't know.
f
a ru - b - ric Yes, yes Ka - tie,
f
what you mean, Pro - fe-ssor Gei - ger there is no ru - b - ric. My
f

217

I need to know - pro - fe - ssor

There is no ru - b - ric

stu - dent asked me and I can't ex - plain. Pro - fe - ssor

mp

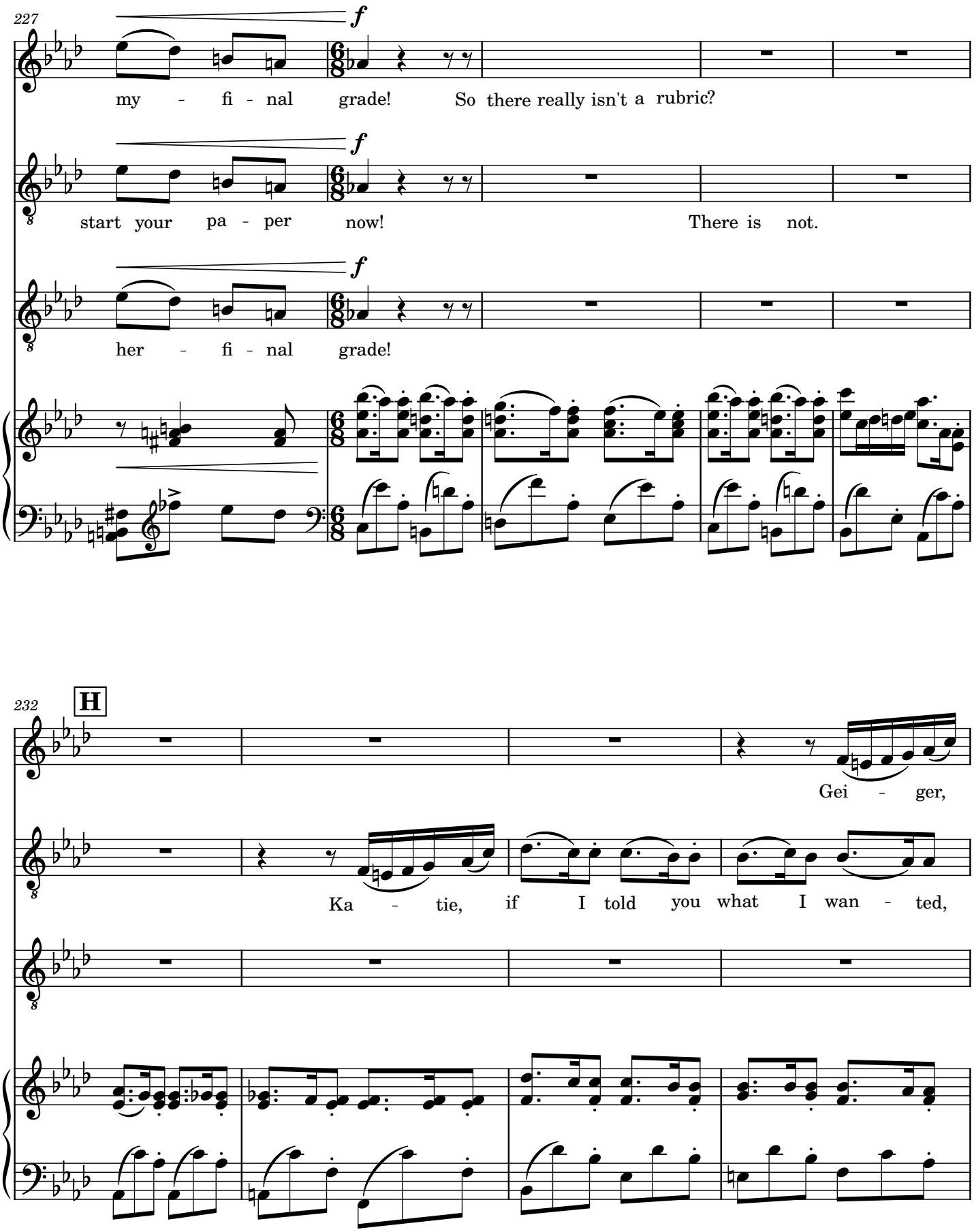
222

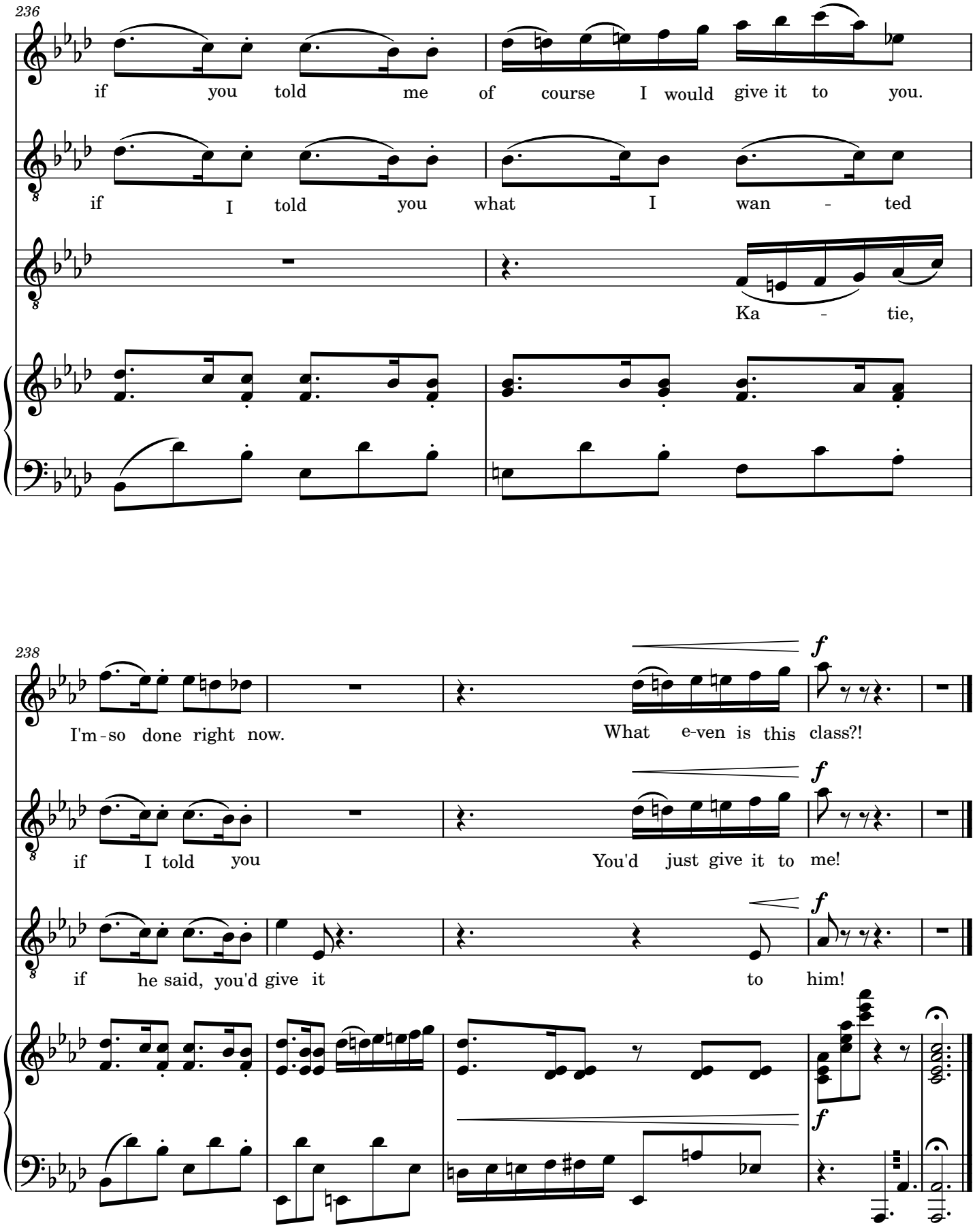
f

Gei - ger I rea - lly go - tta know, be - cause this pa - per will de - ter-mine

So just ac - cept it! and just

Gei - ger we thought it fair to ask, be - cause this pa - per will de - ter-mine


227
f
my - fi - nal grade! So there really isn't a rubric?
f
start your pa - per now! There is not.
f
her - fi - nal grade!
232
H
Gei - ger,
Ka - tie, if I told you what I wan - ted,


236
if you told me of course I would give it to you.
if I told you what I wan - ted
Ka - tie,
238
I'm - so done right now.
What e-ven is this class?!
if I told you
You'd just give it to me!
if he said, you'd give it
to him!
f
f
f
f